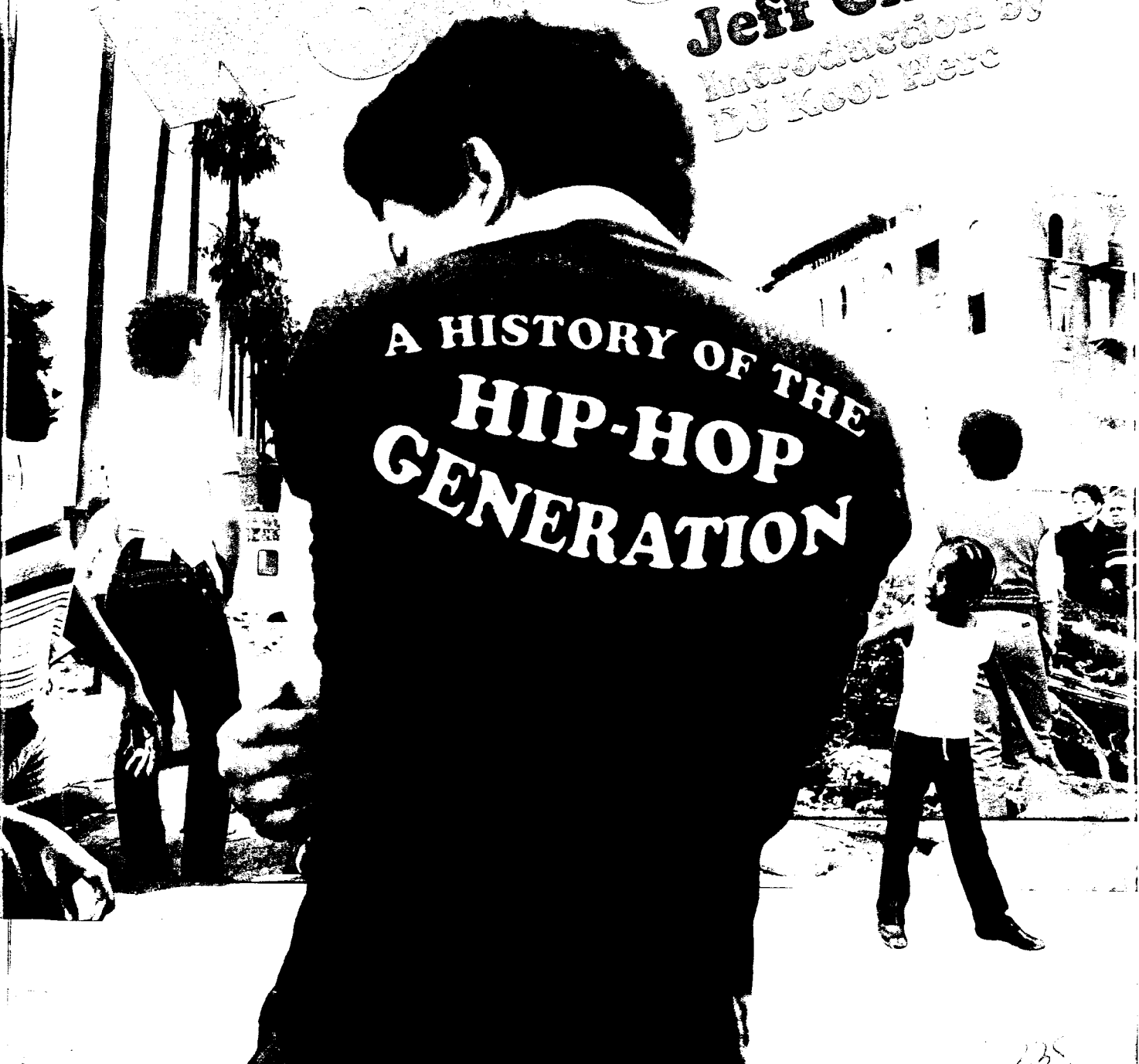


Can't Stop

Jeff Chang
Introduction by
DJ Kool Herc



A HISTORY OF THE
HIP-HOP
GENERATION

2.

Sipple Out Deh

Jamaica's Roots Generation and the Cultural Turn

You know how a thing and the shadow of that thing could be in almost the same place together? You know the way a shadow is a dark version of the real thing, the dub side?

—Nalo Hopkinson

In Jamaica, you drive from the wrong side of the car on the wrong side of the road. Rounding the hill down into Montego Bay, you hug the curves on two-lane roads. Even at rush hour, you slow for cows and goats chewing grass along the gutter side, because apparently all the animals in Jamaica are free-range.

It's dusk on Thursday, a school night, but the youths have taken over Mobay's narrow streets. Traffic is backed up along all of the roads into and out of the seaside town. Even transactions at the turnaround in Sam Sharpe Square—where unmetered taxis swoop in to drop off and pick up customers in a bewildering free-for-all—are slowed by the weight of teenage bodies.

They stream through the streets like tributaries toward the ocean, where, in a waterfront spit of dirt called Urban Development Park, ten-foot high columns of speakers rise in a half-circle around a small stage. The pouting, Tupac-shirted boys and the spandexed, braided girls ripple through the 6:30 P.M. commute—concrete mixers, oil trucks, and family vans caught bumper to bumper on the Bottom Road—and in through a small gap in a low barbed-wire fence. On the field, they pass dice games played by kerosene lamp, higglers selling Red Stripe and Ting. The air smells faintly of ash from mountain fires. Smoke from dozens of portable roast-peanut and jerk-chicken carts hazes the half moon rising.

The rest of the countryside follows. Uniformed schoolchildren swinging



Trenchtown youths, 1976 and 1995.

Photo 1976 © Alex Webb/Magnum Photos

Photo 1995 © Brian Jahn

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their book bags, young denim-skirted mothers with toddlers on arm, the barmaids and working boys stride off their shift and into the dance. The elder locksmen and the gray-haired grannys sway to the music. In the front of an earbleed-inducing bassbin tower, a turbaned Boboshanti gives an inscrutable grin, his fingers touching finger-to-finger, thumb-to-thumb in the sign of the Trinity.

Through modern Jamaican history, much more than musical vibes could be at stake in settings like these. In the dance, political fortunes might rise or fall, society made or undone. If political parties controlled jobs and turf, wealth and despair, they rarely exerted much control here. This was the people's space, an autonomous zone presided over by music men and women, a shelter of collective memory.

Tonight, while the band sets up onstage for a star-studded bill of twenty-first-century dancehall stars, the sound-system operators, housed in a series of special tents that enclose the circle of speakers, drink up and play music. Candle Sound System, the local "foundation sound," is spinning the classics. An old Bob Marley song, "Chances Are," inspires a resounding wheel-up and cries of "Big tune!" It is a thirty-year-old ballad, not danceable, but something more—a sweet echo of the post-independence years, before Marley was an international star, when his was a voice of a young nation bursting with hope and pride. Everyone, no matter their age, seems to know all the words. They sing, "Though my days are filled with sorrow, I see it—a bright tomorrow."

From his turntables, Candle's selector shifts time forward, cueing a Dennis Brown bassline. Another roar of recognition goes up, and a blast of approving airhorns. This time, hundreds of lighters raise, flickering lights over a black sea. As Brown sings the opening lines—"Do you know what it takes to have a revolution?"—the country youths release their aerosol cans into the butane. At the start of a new century, they recreate an elemental, biblical sight. Against the purple sunset, bolts of flames shoot up, tongues of fire licking up the night sky like history and prophecy.

The blues had Mississippi, jazz had New Orleans. Hip-hop has Jamaica. Pioneer DJ Kool Herc spent his earliest childhood years in the same Second Street yard that had produced Bob Marley. "Them said nothing good ever come outta Trenchtown," Herc says. "Well, hip-hop came out of Trenchtown!"

Reggae, it has often been said, is rap music's elder kin. Yet the story runs much deeper than just music. During the 1970s, Marley and the roots generation—the first to come of age after the island nation received independence from Great Britain in 1962—reacted to Jamaica's national crisis, global restructuring and imperialist posturing, and intensified street violence. Seeing politics exhausted, they channeled their energies into culture, and let it flow around the world. They pulled global popular culture into the Third World. Their story is the prelude to the hip-hop generation, felt as a portentous shudder from the dub side. "Some are leaves, some are branches," Bob Marley had sung. "I and I a di roots."

So Long Rastafari Call You

When the 1970s opened in Jamaica, national pride was surging.

A song contest had played a major role. In 1966, Edward Seaga, a ranking conservative in the leading Jamaican Labour Party (JLP), who had been one of the first music executives to record indigenous music, instituted the annual Jamaica Festival Song Competition. The contest supported the young island industry and fostered national identity by introducing and making stars of patwa-singing, ghetto-identifying artists like Toots and the Maytals and Eric Donaldson. Long before many of his contemporaries, Seaga understood that Jamaica was the kind of place where it was hard to tell where the politics ended and the music began.

But the economy, still dependent on the former colonial arrangements, sputtered. Banana farming needed price supports and protection. The bauxite and tourist industries—the kind of businesses that extracted more than they put in—were growing, but had little effect on an island where more than one in three was unemployed. Here was where the optimism of official nationalism broke down.

The gospel of Rastafari offered faith, history, prophecy and redemption, a people's nationalism that countered the official nationalism. Rastafarians followed in the tradition of the Black nationalist Marcus Mosiah Garvey. Born in 1887 in the northern town of St. Ann's Bay, Garvey's mother had wanted to name him Moses. His followers in the Black diaspora of the Caribbean, North and Central America, and Africa—which, at the peak of his powers, likely numbered in the millions—called him the Black Moses.

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Inspired by Booker T. Washington's *Up From Slavery*, and moved by the debased condition of Black farmers and canal workers he met on a visit to Panama, Garvey returned to the streets of Kingston to preach Black redemption and repatriation to a united Africa. He founded the United Negro Improvement Association in 1914 to formally spread the message. "Wake up Ethiopia! Wake up Africa!" he told his followers. "Let us work towards the one glorious end of a free, redeemed, and mighty nation. Let Africa be a bright star among the constellation of nations."

Two years later, Garvey left for Harlem after followers discovered he had used organization funds to pay for his living expenses. In the United States, Garvey's fiscal weaknesses were further exploited when he became the political target of a young Justice Department official named J. Edgar Hoover. But while his reputation had been sullied, his words remained the stuff of prophecy. He had said, "We Negroes believe in the God of Ethiopia, the everlasting God—God the Son, God the Holy Ghost, the one God of all ages." And by the mid-1930s, former Garveyites found that God in the figure of Ethiopia's newly crowned emperor, born Ras Tafari—"Ras" meaning "Duke" in Amharic and "Tafari" the surname of the royal family—and renamed Haile Selassie, "The Might of The Trinity."

To the followers of Rastafari, Selassie was god made flesh, the King of Kings, the conquering lion of Judah, the redeemer and the deliverer of the Black masses who had come in accordance with Garvey's prophecy. Rastafarianism was an indigenous fusion of messianism and millenarianism, anticolonialism and Black nationalism, and it gave the cause of "Black supremacy" spiritual, political, and social dimensions. The religion found a fast following in the impoverished western Kingston ghettos, especially in the yard called Back-O-Wall, where Rastas constructed a camp of wood and tin. Through the mid-1960s, amidst frequent and constant run-ins with the colonial authorities, their influence over the tenement yards grew.

Under a musician named Count Ossie, Rastafarians learned Burru drumming, an African art that had survived from the days of slavery and had come to the Kingston ghettos after slavery was abolished. Burru centered on the interplay of three drums—the bass drum, the alto *fundeh*, and the repeater. The repeater was reserved for the best drummer, who imbued it, in the scholar Verena Reckford's

words, with color and tension, protest and defiance.¹ DJs, the Jamaican term for rappers, would later mimic the play of the Burru repeaters over reggae instrumentals, echoes across time.

Count Ossie gave the Rastas a medium for their message, and the drumming spread with Rastafarianism across Kingston from camp to camp. Ossie would receive and mentor many of the most important Jamaican ska, rock steady and reggae musicians at his haven on Wareika Hill. Due in no small part to his efforts, Jamaican musicians began to blend the popular New Orleans rhythm-and-blues with elements of folk mento, jonkanoo, kumina and Revival Zion styles into a new sound.

But while Rasta thought—first in coded forms, then gradually more explicitly—spread through popular music, the authorities portrayed Rastas as bizarre cultists. Many of Jamaica's Black and brown strivers held the same opinion. As a child in Kingston, DJ Kool Herc recalls, he was told that anyone who had their hair twisted up was, in local parlance, a badman. In 1966, Rastas began to move from the margins to the mainstream of Jamaican society. On April 21, Haile Selassie came to Jamaica and was greeted by a gathering of more than a hundred thousand followers. As the plane landed, the rain stopped, which all gathered took for a sign.

"I remember watching it on TV," DJ Kool Herc recalls. "They took buses and trucks and bicycles and any type of means of transportation, going to the airport for this man who they looked upon as a god. That's when Jamaica really found out there was a force on the island.

"When that the plane came down, they stormed the tarmac," he continues. "Haile Selassie came out and looked at the people and went back on the plane and cried. He didn't know he was worshiped that strongly." The Rastas were exuberant, and their ranks swelled with new converts.

But three months later, history took another sharp turn. Seaga—then the Minister of Community Development and Welfare—was in need of a new political base. The JLP leader, former music exec, and cultural patron was an ambitious man with dangerous connections. He once faced down some hecklers at a political rally by saying, "If they think they are bad, I can bring the crowds of West Kingston. We can deal with you in any way at any time. It will be fire for fire, and blood for blood."²

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Now Seaga fingered the Back-O-Wall ghetto, the west Kingston yard where the camps of the Boboshanti and two other Rasta sects thrived. It was an area that had voted for the opposing political party, the democratic socialist People's National Party (PNP), and Seaga wanted it cleared. So on the morning of July 12, armed police filled the air with tear gas, and dispersed the residents with batons and rifles. Bulldozers rolled in behind the police, flattening the shanties. "When the first raided camp was demolished," Leonard Barrett reported, "a blazing fire of unknown origin consumed what remained to ashes while the fire company stood by."³

On the site, Seaga built a housing project named Tivoli Gardens and moved in a voting constituency of JLP supporters. He recruited and armed young badmen to protect the area and expand the JLP turf, a gang that called itself, appropriately enough, the Phoenix.⁴ The lines were now drawn for generations to come.

"And I can see it with my own eyes," Culture sang a decade later on "Two Sevens Clash." "It's only a housing scheme that divides." Politics, apocalypse—some reasoned—was it a coincidence the two words sounded so similar?

Globalizing the Roots Rebel

In 1973, Jamaica's record industry was on the verge of a major international breakthrough. Up until then, the island had produced occasional novelty hits, like Millie Small's "My Boy Lollipop," that crossed over from Britain's growing West Indian immigrant community to the Top of the Pops and the American top 40. But with the twin vehicles of film and music, the Third World roots rebel made his global debut.

Debuting in Jamaica in 1972, with wider global release the following year, Perry Henzell's movie *The Harder They Come* was a portrait of the Jamaica few yankees would ever trod. The movie opened with a country bus navigating a narrow northern road, the coconut trees of the stormy coastline eerily headless, their fronds and fruits sheered off by plague. Singer Jimmy Cliff played Ivan O. Martin, a peasant making the well-worn trip from rural parish to concrete jungle, the metaphoric journey of a newly freed nation into modernity. But this was not to be a narrative of progress.

Vincent "Ivanhoe" Martin was a real-life fifties Kingston outlaw who renamed himself Rhygin and summoned Jamaica's Maroon pride. *The Harder They Come* updated his story for a nation defining its postcolonial identity in and through its

homegrown popular music. Cliff's Ivan was to be exploited by a greedy music producer, reviled by a Christian pastor, and eventually tortured and hunted by corrupt police. A country *bwai* innocent remade into the urban renegade Rhygin, he shoots down a cop and goes underground. A picture of him posing with two pistols hits the papers and his song controls the airwaves. "As sure as the sun will shine, I'm gonna get my share now, what's mine," he sings, "and then the harder they come, the harder they'll fall, one and all." The new legend of Rhygin would frame the island's turbulent seventies.

In another landmark 1973 film, *Enter the Dragon*, Jim Kelly's African-American activist character Williams had gazed at Bruce Lee's Hong Kong home from a sampan and said, "Ghettos are the same all over the world. They stink." Like Bruce Lee, the Third World reggae heroes seemed to First World audiences an intriguing mix of the familiar and fresh. The soundtrack to Henzell's film, and the debut album by Bob Marley and the Wailers positioned reggae as a quintessential rebel music, steeped in a different kind of urban Black authenticity.

The Wailers' album, *Catch a Fire*, would be a product of the sometimes giddy, sometimes halting dialogue between Third World roots and First World pop. When Bob Marley delivered the rough master tapes to the Island Records offices in London in the dead winter of 1972, a lot was riding on the getting the mix right.

Just months earlier, the Wailers had been stranded in Britain, abandoned by their manager after a European tour failed to materialize. Island Records head Chris Blackwell, a prominent financier of Henzell's film, bailed them out by signing them, advancing them £4,000, and sending them home to Kingston to record the album. They took their opportunity seriously—it was a chance for the boys from Trenchtown to bring the message of Jamaican sufferers to the world.

Blackwell, a wealthy white descendant of Jamaican rum traders now living in London, was beginning to have success in the rock market, and knew he might be on a fool's mission in trying to cross reggae over. But, emboldened by the success of *The Harder They Come*, and embittered by Jimmy Cliff's snubbing to sign a deal with EMI, he was eager to see how far reggae could be taken into the mainstream. He gave the Wailers fancy album packaging and put them on tour with rock and funk bands. Most importantly, he sent the music back for overdubs by rock session musicians, keyboardist Rabbit Bundrick and guitarist Wayne Perkins.

The album's leadoff track, "Concrete Jungle," illustrated the perils and prom-

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ise of translating Jamaican music for First World audiences. The opening notes drifted into a disorienting key, Robbie Shakespeare's bassline seemed to omit more notes than were played, Bunny Wailer and Peter Tosh's harmonies floated and attacked like rope-a-dope boxing. Marley's lyrics described the unrelenting bleakness of the west Kingston yard. "No chains around my feet," the Wailers sang, "but I'm not free." It was utterly brilliant, but the music, Blackwell decided, sounded far too Jamaican.

When he first played the music to Perkins, the Muscle Shoals guitarist couldn't understand the riptide of riddims. But as the song built to the break, Perkins cut loose with a bluesy torrent, culminating in a ringing sustain. Blackwell and engineer Tony Platt hit the echo machine and the note fed back, soaring up two octaves. "It gave me goosebumps, it was one of those magical moments," Perkins says.⁵ Marley, who had spent long, cold, destitute years in America pursuing his pop dream, thought so, too.

Their album would only sell 14,000 copies in its first year, but the Wailers had taken the first step in turning their local music into an international phenomenon. *Catch a Fire* was a landmark moment in the globalization of Third World culture. Fulfilling the destiny the elder Rastas in Trenchtown had long seen for him, Marley was on his way to becoming a worldwide icon of freedom struggle and Black liberation—the small axe becoming the first trumpet.

Sounds and Versions

The pop audience demanded heroes and icons, but reggae, perhaps more than any other music in the world, also privileged the invisible music men, the sonic architects—the studio producer and the sound system selector. Together, during the seventies, these two secretive orders emerged as sources of power in Jamaica.

One center, though it may not have seemed so at the time, was an odd backyard studio in the Kingston suburb of Washington Gardens. Lee "Scratch" Perry, its eccentric owner, was a diminutive man with a feverishly large imagination. Beginning in December of 1973, and continuing night and day for five years, Perry recorded an unceasing parade of harmony groups, singers, and DJs in the tiny, stuffy, concrete structure that he called the Black Ark. The music emerging from the Ark—including Junior Murvin's "Police and Thieves," The Heptones' "Mr. President," and The Congos' "Children Crying"—was mesmerizing and shocking, and would soon reverberate across the globe.

It was a gloriously weird place, this Black Ark, another autonomous zone. Its exterior walls sported a blue, red, and white image of Emperor Haile Selassie and the Lion of Judah, surrounded by purple handprints and footprints like a child's finger paintings. The interior walls were painted red and green, and were crammed with Rasta imagery, Bruce Lee posters, Upsetters album jackets, Teac equipment brochures, Polaroid shots, record stampers, horseshoes, and other ephemera, all covered over by a dense layer of Perry's obscure, signifying graffiti.

Behind a cheap four-track mixing desk, which by the standards of the time was hopelessly outdated, Perry whirled and bopped and twiddled the knobs, imbuing the recordings with wild crashes of echo, gravity-defying phasing, and frequency-shredding equalization. Influenced by his work with Osborne "King Tubby" Ruddock, Perry used aging analog machines like the Echoplex to turn sounds over and back into themselves like Möbius loops. Melodies became fragments, fragments became signs, and the whole thing swirled like a hurricane.

Upon his arrival in Kingston from his native northern countryside in 1960, Perry had headed straight for the powerful sound systems to try to find work, eventually becoming a songwriter for Duke Reid, then moving on to become a scout and operator for Reid's competitor, Coxsone Dodd. According to dancehall historian Norman Stolzoff, sound system culture had evolved in Kingston after World War II when the ranks of live musicians dramatically thinned due to immigration to the United Kingdom and the United States and the rise of the North Coast tourist industry.⁶ By the time Perry came to Kingston, sound systems had largely replaced live bands.

Outfitted with powerful amplifiers and blasting stacks of homemade speakers, one only needed a selector and records to transform any yard. The sound systems democratized pleasure and leisure by making dance entertainment available to the downtown sufferers and strivers. The sound systems championed the people's choice long before commercial radio, and as independence approached, they moved from playing mostly American rhythm-and-blues to homegrown ska, rock steady, and finally, reggae.

The fiercely competitive sound systems—including Duke Reid's Trojan, Coxsone Dodd's Downbeat the Ruler, Prince Buster's Voice of the People, King Edwards the Giant, and Tom the Great Sebastian—fought for audiences; some of them even sent thugs to shoot up their rivals' dances and destroy their

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equipment in fits of anger or desperation.⁷ More usually, they distinguished themselves from each other with "specials," records that no other sound system had, songs that mashed up their competitors and drew away their audiences. They even sometimes "clashed" live in the same hall or yard, song for song, "dub fi dub."

Early on, selectors made frequent trips to America to secure obscure exclusives. As the Jamaican music industry expanded during the sixties, sound systems began to record local artists' songs onto exclusive acetates or "dubplates."⁸ In 1967, a sound system head affiliated with Duke Reid named Ruddy Redwood stumbled onto Jamaican music's next great innovation.

One afternoon Redwood was cutting dubplates when engineer Byron Smith forgot to pan up the vocals on The Paragons' hit, "On the Beach." Redwood took the uncorrected acetate to the dance that night anyway, and mixing between the vocal and the dub, sent the crowd into a frenzy during his midnight set. Rather than apologize for his mistake the next day, Redwood emphasized to Reid that the vocal-less riddim could be used as a B-side on the commercial release of the singles. Reid, for his part, realized he could cut his costs by half or more. One studio session could now produce multiple "versions."⁹ A single band session with a harmony trio could be recycled as a DJ version for a rapper to rock *patwa* rhymes over, and a dub version in which the mixing engineer himself became the central performer—experimenting with levels, equalization and effects to alter the feel of the riddim, and break free of the constraints of the standard song.

Dub's birth was accidental, its spread was fueled by economics, and it would become a diagram for hip-hop music. A space had been pried open for the break, for possibility. And, quickly, noise came up from the streets to fill the space—yard-centric toasts, sufferer moans, analog echoes—the sounds of people's histories, *dub histories*, versions not represented in the official version. As musical competition was overshadowed by violent political competition, dub became the sound of a rapidly fragmenting nation—troubling, strange, tragic, wise slow-motion portraits of social collapse.

Roots and Culture

Every Jamaican politician knew what every Jamaican musician knew—the sound systems were crucial to their success. During the seventies, the fight for political

dominance between the conservative Jamaica Labour Party (JLP) and leftist People's National Party (PNP) seemed inevitably to turn on the mood of the people in the dance. All any prime minister had to do to gauge the winds was to listen closely to the week's 45 rpm single releases; they were like political polls set to melody and riddim.

The message was becoming decidedly roots and radical. In the fall of 1968, the JLP-led government had banned Black-power literature and icons like the pan-Africanist leader Walter Rodney from the University of the West Indies campus, then violently crushed the political riots that ensued across the city. But this did not stop the electorate from moving hard left. Intellectuals high on Malcolm X, socialists stricken by Castro, middle-class strivers impatient for price stability, poor strugglers facing dim prospects, even Rastas traditionally reluctant to participate in what Peter Tosh called the Babylon *shitstem* all clamored for change. Sufferer anthems took over the sound systems. The resistance to roots reggae finally gave way on JBC radio, as listeners came home from the yard dances to demand that tunes like Delroy Wilson's "Better Must Come" and the Wailers' "Small Axe" (cut with Perry) be played during daytime hours. Burning Spear summed up the mood of the time: "The people know what it is they want, so they themselves go about getting it."¹⁰

Compared to Seaga, who had worked the nexus of culture and politics for years, Michael Manley, the democratic socialist PNP candidate, was a late-comer. But as Manley geared up for the 1972 elections, he began appearing at political rallies with his "rod of correction," a staff that he said had been handed to him by Haile Selassie, in explicit recognition of the influence Rastafarianism held among the poor. The rod, he said, would lead him to redressing injustice. Befitting his new image, he spoke of reggae as "the people's language," and selected Wilson's "Better Must Come" as his campaign theme. The following year, the PNP swept the JLP out of office. In Laurie Gunst's worlds, Jamaica in the '70s was "a fever-dream of raised consciousness and high hopes."¹¹

But better never came. The twin downpressing forces of Cold War positioning and global economic pressures ripped Jamaica apart.

Manley's democratic socialist government pushed through key social reforms, including lowering the voting age to eighteen, making secondary and university education free, and establishing a national minimum wage. But when Manley

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moved to reestablish relations with Cuba and build solidarity with leftist leaders in the Caribbean and Africa, CIA surveillance sharply intensified, and First World leaders withdrew aid and investments. In 1971, Jamaica received \$23 million in aid from the United States. By 1975, that amount was down to \$4 million.¹²

The worldwide oil crisis-fueled recession hit the Jamaican dollar hard, unleashing economic chaos. Prices tripled while wages declined by half; a paycheck suddenly bought one-sixth of what it used to. Labor unions unleashed an unprecedented number of walkouts. Between 1972 and 1979, there were more than three hundred strikes.

North American banks refused to renew aid loans. Jamaica's debt doubled between 1975 and 1980 to \$2 billion U.S., the equivalent of 90 percent of the country's gross domestic product.¹³ After a bitter internal fight, the PNP reversed course and finally agreed to accept emergency loans for Jamaica from the International Monetary Fund (IMF), who imposed severe austerity measures that caused goods shortages and massive layoffs. The IMF's plan wreaked long-term havoc on the island's economy, wiping out entire industries. To pay off the skyrocketing debt, the PNP raised taxes, causing other businesses to flee the island.

In 1973, gun violence broke out between rival gangs in the Kingston yards. Manley first placed the island "under heavy manners," expanding police powers to search and raid, and stepping up joint police-military operations. He then established a special Gun Court, where gunmen and illegal firearms traffickers faced mandatory indefinite sentences for their crimes.

By the end of 1976, when Manley declared a State of Emergency—the Jamaican equivalent of martial law—it was becoming clear that much of the violence was politically motivated. In the Kingston yards, gangs had divided and mapped their turf. As Seaga had long understood, gang leaders were useful to party machinery—they delivered a yard's votes in election years, fought the ground war during the off years. In turn, politicians granted jobs, favors, and programs to the area dons, who organized the youths into work-groups or militias.

Bounty Killer, the dancehall DJ who grew up in the Riverton neighborhood during the 1970s and '80s, says, "We used to love politics. When time de MP (Member of Parliament) come an' say, 'Bwoy, we a go gi' weh dis an we a go gi' weh dat'—we interested.

"A poor people—weh a look a likkle help an' a look a hope inna Jamaica—a listen when de Govament a talk," he added. "But no hope no deh deh. Dem haffi hold oonu (everyone) inna dat position so dem can get oonu attention."¹⁴ In 1974, singer Little Roy went into the Black Ark to record an anguished plea for peace, "Tribal War," a tune whose cyclical revival over the next three decades spoke to the permanence of political gang violence.

While Seaga and the JLP officials turned up the rhetorical heat on the Manley government in Parliament, the JLP gangs lit up PNP yards with Molotov cocktails and gunfire. PNP gangs retaliated in kind, fire for fire, blood for blood. When firefighters arrived in Rema, a JLP community, in January 1976, they confronted youths tossing stones from behind roadblocks of blazing tires. The shanties were left to burn.¹⁵ Manley felt he saw a design to the violence—a devil's bargain between the CIA and the pro-U.S. JLP, Washington bullets in the Kingston streets. He wrote in his memoirs, "I have no doubt that the CIA was active in Jamaica that year and was working through its own agents to destabilise us."¹⁶

With guns and money flowing to the opposition party, the tribal wars rose to a new pitch. Smoke thickened the heavy air in the zinc yards, and Rhygins in JLP green or PNP red raged through the ghetto. In May, the warfare peaked when gangsters surrounded a tenement yard in West Kingston at Orange Lane and set it ablaze, trapping five hundred residents inside. Gunmen blasted away at the police and firemen who arrived at the scene, and eleven perished in the conflagration. As debate raged in Parliament over which party was responsible for the carnage, and the elections neared, hundreds more were gunned down.

During the tribal wars of the mid-sixties, the Wailers had cut "Simmer Down," a tune encouraging rudies to "control your temper." Now Bob Marley met Lee "Scratch" Perry at the Black Ark to record another track that might cool down the ghetto, "Smile Jamaica," and agreed to do a free concert bearing the same name on December 5. Hearing this news, the PNP scheduled elections for December 20, and made a show of sending armed guards to watch Marley's up-town compound at 56 Hope Road. Marley was enraged. Like many Rastas, he had supported Manley and the PNP in 1972, but now he was disgusted with where *politricks* had led the country.

Two nights before the show, the armed guard mysteriously disappeared. Minutes later, six assassins entered the mansion. Rita Marley was shot in the head,

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and manager Don Taylor took five bullets destined for Bob, whose chest was grazed as the last bullet entered his left arm. But on the night of the show, Bob was wheeled into National Heroes Park, where a crowd of 80,000, including Manley and a large PNP entourage, had gathered. Marley played a triumphant concert, then left for the Bahamas in a self-imposed exile.

Rumors spread that the JLP, perhaps even the CIA, was behind the hit. The point had been made: violence was striking dangerously near the heart of the people.

The Dub Side

And so they sang of clashes, of war. From imagining distant and free African skies in songs like The Abyssinians' "Satta Massa Gana," The Mighty Diamonds' "Africa," Junior Byles's "A Place Called Africa," or Bunny Wailer's "Dreamland," they moved to plead for relief from the violence borne of "isms and schisms."

Leroy Smart's "Ballistic Affair" was a tragic dispatch from the fire-scarred danger zone of Seventh Street, the militarized border between Rema and Concrete Jungle, a PNP yard whose Junglist gang was thought to be behind much of the violence:

We used to lick chalice, cook ital stew together
Play football and cricket as one brother
Now through you rest a Jungle
A you might block a Rema
You a go fight 'gainst your brother.

Max Romeo and Lee "Scratch" Perry captured the moment's treacherous flux. As Romeo told David Katz: "I had this song 'War In A Babylon' where me say, 'It wicked out there, it dread out there.' I took it to [Perry], said, 'You like it?' He said 'Yeah!' with excitement, 'but no dread and no wicked, it *sipple* out deh!' So I said, 'Yeah that have a ring to it', because *sipple* mean slippery, it's slidey out there."¹⁷ In his new chorus, Romeo asked "So wha fi do?" and the answer came, "Mek we *slide* out deh." As the song climaxed, Romeo retreated high up to the Rasta hills as Kingston exploded under the burning sun:

I man satta on the mountaintop
 Watching Babylon burning red hot
 Red hot!

Here was *The Harder They Come's* Ivan, a reef fish battling the ocean current, a flash of color in the tidal surge, pursued by police and enemies, making a last run through the ghetto, leaving graffiti tags on the concrete walls that mocked, "I was here but I disappear (sic)"—laughing mightily, knowing that he'd already become indelible in the public imagination, that even politics could not erase him—and, like a premonitory smoke above the shanty roofs: "I AM EVERYWHERE." Celebrating survival itself was the point.

While singers and DJs offered words of mourning or escape for the sufferers, dub reggae—the mostly wordless music of dread—ran directly into the heart of the darkness. In Perry's "Revelation Dub," time was creakily kept by a distended, phasing hi-hat and Romeo's vocal was either reduced to the low hum of some distant street protest or chopped into sudden nonsensical stabs—"Warinna!" "Balwarin!"—as if all words, even warnings, could not be trusted. The riddim—which Marley would later version for "Three Little Birds," with its bright chorus, "Don't worry about a thing, 'cause every little thing's gonna be alright"—was swung off its moorings, the textual integrity and authority was undermined. Perry's sound was the epitome of *sipple*. Dub answered the question: what kind of mirror is it that reflects everything but the person looking into it?

Dub had a compelling circularity. It exploded in the dancehall at the moment the tenement yards exploded in violence. Dub was the "B-side" to the soaring visions of the democratic socialist dreamers or the apocalyptic warnings of the Rasta prophets. As reggae historian Steve Barrow says, "The music of dub represents literally and figuratively 'the other side.' There's an up and a down, there's an A-side and a B-side. It's a dialectical world."

As the two sevens clashed, dub peaked with album sets from Perry (*Super Ape*), Keith Hudson (*Brand*), Niney the Observer (*Sleagehammer Dub*), the Mighty Two—Joe Gibbs and Errol Thompson (Prince Far I's *Under Heavy Manners*, Joe Gibbs' *State of Emergency*, *African Dub All-Mighty* series), Philip Smart (Tapper Zukie's *Tapper Zukie In Dub*), Harry Mudie (the *Dub Conference* series), and the most influential dubmaster of all, King Tubby.

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Born Osborne Ruddock in 1941, Tubby had collaborated with Perry to demonstrate the possibilities of dub on the 1973 album, *Blackboard Jungle Dub*. With *King Tubbys Meets Rockers Uptown*, an album-length collection of sides with melodica player Augustus Pablo dating to the beginning of Manley's first term, musical innovation and political disintegration seemed to stoke each other.

On the title track, a version of Jacob Miller's "Baby I Love You So," Tubby left Pablo's melodica, Carly Barrett's drums, and Chinna Smith's guitar in shards. Miller had sung, "Night and day, I pray that love will come my way." But Tubby clipped his lines—"Baby I-I-I-I," "night and day," "that love," "And I-I-I-I"—transforming Miller's longing into a prison. On the original, Miller had scatted loosely, then chuckled, perhaps at having missed an essential cue. Tubby added a ghostly echo, leaving the laugh to hang like a haunting, the smoke of Rhygin's trail. At the end, Miller's cry dissolved in a barrage of oscillations, a plunge through a trapdoor.

The last track, inexplicably left unannounced on the original album sleeve and label, was a dub of the Abyssinians' 1969 single, "Satta Massa Gana," colloquially known as the Rastafarian national anthem. In mistranslated Amharic, its title meant to "give thanks and praise" to Haile Selassie, while its harmonies yearned for "a land far far away."¹⁸ Tubby gutted the song to a bass pulse and drum accent. The song's basic chords were twisted out of shape and pitch. Drums dropped like thunderclaps. Tubby's mirror world was the sound of the dreamland alliance of Rastas and democratic socialists disintegrating, its utopia looted by thugs and left to the whipping hurricane winds of global change.

It was music of the crossfire lifted out of the progression of time, politics, and meaning. Dub embraced contingency. Everything was up for grabs. Dub declaimed, distorted, or dropped out at the razor's edge of a moment. It gave a clipped, fragmented voice to horrors the nation could not yet adequately articulate.

One Love Peace Music

When 1978 arrived, another round of election-year violence seemed imminent. But then the unexpected happened. Somehow in early January, Bucky Marshall, a gunman from the PNP-backed Spanglers Posse, ended up in the same General Penitentiary cell as some JLP gangsters and they got to talking.

They spoke of the event that had ended 1977. Renegade soldiers from the Jamaican Defense Force had set up and ambushed an unarmed posse of JLP roughnecks, killing five. But five more got away, and they told the story of the extra-legal set-up to *The Gleaner*. The resulting scandal potentially incriminated both PNP and JLP politicians, and many felt that a coup or a civil war was imminent. Certainly, the rival gunmen in that jail-cell reasoned, no political affiliations could save anyone from the army if something that serious was afoot.

When Marshall stepped out of jail, he went to meet with Claudie Massop, Seaga's man in Tivoli Gardens, who had come up through The Phoenix and was now the area don. The next morning, at a spot straddling the border of JLP and PNP territories in central Kingston, they announced a peace treaty. Marshall and Massop took photos together, and spoke to the press. "This is not political," said Marshall. "This is from we who have felt the pangs of jail."¹⁹ Massop added, "The youths have been fighting among themselves for too long and is only them get dead. Everybody I grow up with is dead."²⁰ Amidst the spreading truce, elated youths left their yards and began to gather in parks and dances that had formerly been in enemy territory.

With the help of the Rasta sect, the Twelve Tribes of Israel, Marshall, Massop, and the ranking PNP don from Concrete Jungle, "Red Tony" Welch, went to London to see the man who had first brought them together, Bob Marley. Welch and Massop had been frequent guests when Marley was holding court on Hope Road. Now they asked him to return to Jamaica and headline a "One Love Peace Concert." The benefit would raise money for the most suffering PNP and JLP ghettos, to be distributed by the newly formed Central Peace Council, but more importantly, it could curtail the possibility of civil war or a military coup. Marley agreed, and flew home. In the days leading to the concert, Marley toured through the yards to talk up the peace treaty. At the Black Ark, he and Perry recorded "Blackman Redemption" and "Rastaman Live Up" as Massop and Marshall vibed together in the listening room.²¹

On April 22, thousands packed Kingston's National Stadium to hear the island's top musicians, including Dennis Brown, Culture, the Mighty Diamonds, Big Youth, Beres Hammond, Ras Michael and the Sons of Negus, Dillinger and Jacob Miller, who, with his band Inner Circle, had the most popular tune in the country in "Peace Treaty Special," a rockers-style tribute to Marshall, Massop and the tribes set to a version of the American Civil War-era song, "When

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Johnny Comes Marching Home Again.”²² “Man can walk the street again, hurrah-ah-e-ah hurrah,” Miller sang joyously. “From Tivoli to Jungle, Lizard Town to Rema—hurrah!” Peter Tosh played a scorching set, laced with withering criticisms of the politicians in attendance. Then Marley took the stage, and the crowd swelled to a roar.

As the Wailers gave an inspired performance of “Jamming,” Marley called the political leaders onstage. His long dreads cut arcs through the night air, and he danced as if possessed, singing, “Show the people that you love ‘em right, show the people you gonna unite.” Manley stood to the left of Marley, Seaga to the right, and they tentatively gave each other a handshake. Marley clasped their hands, put them in a power grip and lifted them over his head, holding them high for all to see. The crowd was stunned. “Love, prosperity be with us all,” Marley said. “Jah Rastafari. Selassie I.”

Through music, Marley had brought together a trinity of power, and restored unity to the young nation. Culture, it seemed, had transcended politics.

The Pressure Drop

But there were other signs as well. Five days before the concert, army soldiers fired on a peaceful ghetto march for better sanitation, killing three demonstrators. The leader of the Central Peace Council, who had called for an end to police corruption, fled the island in fear for his life. Police stopped and searched a taxi Claudie Massop was riding in, then coldly executed him in a hail of fifty bullets.²³ The peace treaty was over. So was Manley’s democratic socialist experiment. In 1980, Seaga and the JLP would be overwhelmingly victorious at the polls, stepping up just in time to be courted by the new Reagan administration in Washington. Almost nine hundred people would die in election-year violence.

The reggae industry, too, felt the pressure drop. During the heady independence years of the sixties, Coxson Dodd’s Studio One and Duke Reid’s Treasure Isle had been built from local sound system profits. But the Black Ark studio had been financed by the globalization of the reggae industry. Perry’s dubs had been partly an answer to the growing international demand for reggae. Reggae music was not only a socially stabilizing force, it had become an important commodity.

The pressures fell disproportionately on the slender shoulders of musicians.

Uptown, Bob Marley's Hope Road residence had become a magnet for Twelve Tribes Rastas, a sect that openly and controversially courted the wealthy, whites and browns. But many more displaced sufferers also frequented the Hope Road yard. Marley archivist Roger Steffens believes that by the late '70s, Marley was directly responsible for the economic fortunes of six thousand people. By 1979, the Marley camp had also become aware of CIA operatives tailing them. And yet, despite being diagnosed with cancer, Marley maintained a hectic touring schedule through the end of 1980, perhaps because of such obligations. "It took its toll," Steffens says. "He really wanted out." On May 11, 1981, he was dead.

At the beginning of 1978, Perry's Black Ark had become a center for the Boboshanti, an orthodox Rasta sect led by Prince Emmanuel Edwards that adhered to the ideal of Black Supremacy. Perry biographer David Katz notes that the Bobos hoped Perry and his Ark could help disseminate their message, much the same way Marley did for the Twelve Tribes, and that hundreds of people materially depended upon Perry's riddim factory. By the end of the year, Perry had ejected the Bobos, shaved his budding dreads, and turned away Rasta groups and visitors. He began dismantling the studio. He covered the Ark with brown paint and graffiti tags, crossing out words and pictures with Xs. In the summer of 1983, the Black Ark burned to the ground. Perry said he did it himself.

Years later, Perry dictated an extraordinary statement to Katz, a peripatetic freestyle. He began, "The First World and the Second World live, but the Third World is finished because I, Lee 'Scratch' Perry, knows the head of the IMF—the IMF big boss, the Bank of England big boss, the Midland big boss, the International Giro Bank big boss . . .

"The Third World drawn in," he continued. "The game blocked; the road block, the lane block, and the street block, so who can't see good better see them eye specialist and take a good look upon the road. The road blocked; all the roads are blocked . . .

"Reggae music is a curse, the ultimate destruction", he said. "Logical Fox, solid-state logic."²⁴

Fevered dreams of progress had brought fires to the Bronx and Kingston. The hip-hop generation, it might be said, was born in these fires.

4.

Making a Name

How DJ Kool Herc Lost His Accent and Started Hip-Hop

... the logic is an extension rather than a negation. Alias, a.k.a.; the names describe a process of loops. From A to B and back again.

Paul D. Miller

It has become myth, a creation myth, this West Bronx party at the end of the summer in 1973. Not for its guests—a hundred kids and kin from around the way, nor for the setting—a modest recreation room in a new apartment complex; not even for its location—two miles north of Yankee Stadium, near where the Cross-Bronx Expressway spills into Manhattan. Time remembers it for the night DJ Kool Herc made his name.

The plan was simple enough, according to the party's host, Cindy Campbell. "I was saving my money, because what you want to do for back to school is go down to Delancey Street instead of going to Fordham Road, because you can get the newest things that a lot of people don't have. And when you go back to school, you want to go with things that nobody has so you could look nice and fresh," she says. "At the time my Neighborhood Youth Corps paycheck was like forty-five dollars a week—ha!—and they would pay you every two weeks. So how am I gonna turn over my money? I mean, this is not enough money!"

Cindy calculated it would cost a little more than half her paycheck to rent the rec room in their apartment building at 1520 Sedgwick Avenue. Her brother, whom she knew as Clive but everyone else knew as Kool Herc, was an aspiring DJ with access to a powerful sound system. All she had to do was bulk-buy some Olde English 800 malt liquor, Colt 45 beer, and soda, and advertise the party.

She, Clive and her friends hand-wrote the announcements on index cards,

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scribbling the info below a song title like "Get on the Good Foot" or "Fence-walk." If she filled the room, she could charge a quarter for the girls, two for the guys, and make back the overhead on the room. And with the profit—presto, instant wardrobe.

Clive had been DJing house parties for three years. Growing up in Kingston, Jamaica, he had seen the sound systems firsthand. The local sound was called Somerset Lane, and the selector's name was King George. Clive says, "I was too young to go in. All we could do is sneak out and see the preparation of the dance throughout the day. The guys would come with a big old handcart with the boxes in it. And then in the night time, I'm a little itchy headed, loving the vibrations on the zinc top 'cause them sound systems are powerful.

"We just stay outside like everybody else, you know, pointing at the gangsters as they come up, all the famous people. And at the time they had the little motorcycles, Triumphs and Hondas. Rudeboys used to have those souped up. They used to come up four and five six deep, with them *likkle* ratchet knife," Clive says. He still remembers the crowd's buzz when Claudie Massop arrived at a local dance one night. He wanted to be at the center of that kind of excitement, to be a King George.

Cindy and Clive's father, Keith Campbell, was a devoted record collector, buying not only reggae, but American jazz, gospel, and country. They heard Nina Simone and Louis Armstrong and Nat King Cole, even Nashville country crooner Jim Reeves. "I remember listening to Jim Reeves all the time," Clive says. "I was singing these songs and emulating them to the fullest. That really helped me out, changing my accent, is singing to the records."

In the Bronx, his mother, Nettie, would take him to house parties, which had the same ambrosial effect on him that the sound systems had. "I see the different guys dancing, guys rapping to girls, I'm wondering what the guy is whisperin' in the girl's ears about. I'm green, but I'm checking out the scene," he recalls. "And I noticed a lot of the girls was complaining, 'Why they not playing that record?' 'How come they don't have that record?' 'Why did they take it off right there?'" He began buying his own 45s, waiting for the day he could have his own sound system.

As luck would have it, Keith Campbell became a sponsor for a local rhythm and blues band, investing in a brand new Shure P.A. system for the group.

Clive's father was now their soundman, and the band wanted somebody to play records during intermission. Keith told them he could get his son. But Clive had started up his own house party business, and somehow his gigs always happened to fall at the same times as the band's, leaving Keith so angry he refused to let Clive touch the system. "So here go these big columns in my room, and my father says, 'Don't touch it. Go and borrow Mr. Dolphy's stuff,'" he says. "Mr. Dolphy said, 'Don't worry Clive, I'll let you borrow some of these.' In the back of my mind, Jesus Christ, I got these big Shure columns up in the room!"

At the same time, his father was no technician. They all knew the system was powerful, but no one could seem to make it peak. Another family in the same building had the same system and seemed to be getting more juice out of it, but they wouldn't let Keith or Clive see how they did it. "They used to put a lot of wires to distract me from chasing the wires," he says.

One afternoon, fiddling around on the system behind his father's back, Clive figured it out. "What I did was I took the speaker wire, put a jack onto it and jacked it into one of the channels, and I had extra power and reserve power. Now I could control it from the preamp. I got two Bogart amps, two Girard turntables, and then I just used the channel knobs as my mixer. No headphones. The system could take eight mics. I had an echo chamber in one, and a regular mic to another. So I could talk plain and, at the same time, I could wait halfway for the echo to come out.

"My father came home and it was so loud he snuck up behind me," he remembers. Clive's guilt was written all over his face. But his father couldn't believe it.

Keith yelled, "Where the noise come from?"

"This is the system!"

Keith said, "What! Weh you did?"

"This is what I did," Clive recalls telling his father, revealing the hookup.

"And he said, 'Raas claat, man! We 'ave sound!!!'

"So now the tables turned. Now these other guys was trying to copy what I was doing, because our sound is coming out monster, monster!" Clive says. "Me and my father came to a mutual understanding that I would go with them and play between breaks and when I do my parties, I could use the set. I didn't have to borrow his friend's sound system anymore. I start making up business

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cards saying 'Father and Son.' And that's how it started, man! That's when Cindy asked me to do a back-to-school party. Now people would come to this party and see these big-ass boxes they never seen before."

It was the last week in August of 1973. Clive and his friends brought the equipment down from their second floor apartment and set up in the room adjacent to the rec room. "My system was on the dance floor, and I was in a little room watching, peeking out the door seeing how the party was going," he says.

It didn't start so well. Clive played some dancehall tunes, ones guaranteed to rock any yard dance. Like any proud DJ, he wanted to stamp his personality onto his playlist. But this was the Bronx. They wanted the breaks. So, like any good DJ, he gave the people what they wanted, and dropped some soul and funk bombs. Now they were packing the room. There was a new energy. DJ Kool Herc took the mic and carried the crowd higher.

"All people would hear is his voice coming out from the speakers," Cindy says. "And we didn't have no money for a strobe light. So what we had was this guy named Mike. When Herc would say, 'Okay, Mike! Mike with the lights!', Mike flicked the light switch. He got paid for that."

By this point in the night, they probably didn't need the atmospherics. The party people were moving to the shouts of James Brown, turning the place into a sweatbox. They were busy shaking off history, having the best night of their generation's lives.

Later, as Clive and Cindy counted their money, they were giddy. This party could be the start of something big, they surmised. They just couldn't know how big.

Sacrifices

Clive Campbell was born the first of six children to Keith and Nettie Campbell. Nettie had moved to the city from Port Maria on the northern coast. Keith, a city native, worked as the head foreman at the Kingston Wharf garage, a working-class job with status.

Keith was something of a community leader, he held the kind of job title that drew the attention of politicians. But he chose not to take sides when the JLP and PNP began their violent jockeying for position. The year before Clive left for the United States, Edward Seaga had unleashed the West Kingston War in Back-

O-Wall. Clive says, "I remember police riding around in big old trucks, tanks. And some people who were brothers or friends would turn on each other. It was like a civil war."

By then, the Campbells no longer lived in Trenchtown near the frontlines. They had moved east across the city to a house in Franklyn Town, a quieter urban neighborhood of strivers below Warieka Hill and the upper-class neighborhood called Beverly Hills. It was a modest but lush property near the famous Alpha Boys School.

"We had like seven different fruits growing in our yard. We had different types of peppers, flowers, you know, it was tight!" Clive recalls. "We wasn't too far away from the beach. So, as a matter of fact, it was a traditional thing with us for my father to take us to the beach on Sunday. Every Sunday we'd look forward to go out to the beach after church."

The Campbells were able to afford a housekeeper. Their grandfather, aunts and older cousins all pitched in to raise the children, a fact that would become significant when Nettie decided to supplement the family income by working and studying in the United States. Many other Jamaicans were already leaving for Miami, London, Toronto and New York City to escape the instability and seek their fortune. During the early 1960s, Nettie had departed for Manhattan to work as a dental technician and to study for a nursing degree. She saved money to send home and returned with a degree, convinced that the United States offered a better future for the family.

Cindy says, "She saw the opportunities. The public schools were free, because in Jamaica we went to private schools. So she told my father that when she finished with school that what she wanted was for the family to live here. And he didn't want to come."

But Keith could see Nettie's reasoning. Even his own friends and relatives were leaving the country. Before Nettie returned to New York City in 1966, they agreed to move to America. Clive would be the first to join her, then the rest of the family would follow. Cindy says, "A lot of immigrants have to do that. You have to make sacrifices. It breaks up the family for a small amount of time but eventually the family gets back together."

Clive and Cindy agree that Keith remained a Jamaican at heart. "He just said, 'America was a place for you to excel and do better for your kids.' But af-

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ter a while you go back home, you go back to your country. And he believed in that. He loved his country," Cindy says. Years later, after raising his children with Nettie in New York City and becoming an American citizen, he returned to his beloved island for a visit. While swimming in strong currents off Bull Bay, he had a heart attack. The Campbells buried him in Jamaica.

Becoming American

From Kingston to the Bronx. Stones that the builders refused.

Clive Campbell came to New York City on a cold November night in 1967. A fresh snowfall lay on the ground, something the twelve-year-old had never seen before. He took a bus from Kennedy Airport into the gray, unwelcoming city. This wasn't the America he had seen on his neighbor's television, or imagined from his father's records. He had no idea how to begin again, he says, "All I could do was just look out the window."

His mother's apartment was at 611 East 178th Avenue, between the Bronx's Little Italy and Crotona Park, in what had been the Cross-Bronx Expressway's most contested mile. "Now I'm living in a tenement building. There's no yard. This is all boxed and closed in," Clive recalls. His mother feared Clive would fall prey to the heroin plague. She told Clive, "Don't let anybody tell you they're gonna stick something in your arm. Don't let them trick you by calling you chicken."

Clive looked and spoke and felt like a country boy. "Here I am all hicked out, got a corduroy coat on, with the snow hat with the flip-up-and-come-over-your-ears. I had that on with these cowboy boots," Herc recalls. "And this girl at school started teasing the hell out of me. She was calling my shoes 'roach killers.' She had the whole hall laughing, 'Ah roach killers, roach killers!'"

"At that time, being Jamaican wasn't fashionable. Bob Marley didn't come through yet to make it more fashionable, to even give a chance for people to listen to our music," he says. "I remember one time a guy said, 'Clive, man, don't walk down that way cause they throwing Jamaicans in garbage cans.' The gangs was throwing Jamaicans in garbage cans!"

Herc was learning the ways of the Bronx. He found himself hanging out with young Five Percenters, absorbing their slang and science. For a time, he even rolled with the Cofon Cats, the same Tremont gang that Benjy Melendez had

joined when he first moved to the Bronx a few years before. It wasn't much of an experience. The Cofon Cats spent one long afternoon getting chased out of Little Italy by the Golden Guineas.

At Junior High School 118, Clive began running cross-country and track and winning medals. His physicality won him American friends. After school, he began hanging out with a Jamaican American named Jerome Wallace, who was a unicyclist. Jerome had already been through the transition Clive was going through. He taught Clive how to ride on one wheel, and how to balance his Jamaican past and his Bronx present. Clive began to see the Cofon Cats as punks who were nothing without the security of the gang. "The gang members started asking us to be division leaders because they see we have respect. So we didn't need that anymore," Herc says. "And I had a few other things to worry about besides the gangs, like getting my ass whipped by my father."

Clive tuned into rock and soul disc jockeys like Cousin Brucie and Wolfman Jack as if he had caught religion, listening to these smooth men rap their silver-tongued rap. He began going to "First Fridays" youth dances at a local Catholic school and at Murphy Projects. His mother took him to house parties, where he heard music he had never heard on WBLS or WWRL. The Temptations, Aretha Franklin, Smokey Robinson, and, most important, James Brown became his tutors; they were teaching Clive how to lose his accent.

"I was more around Americans. And I was tired of hearing them say 'What did you say?' My accent really started to change," he recalls. By the time Clive began attending Alfred E. Smith High School, some of his Jamaican friends didn't even know he was Jamaican. He was in the process of reinventing himself, creating a new identity.

He wasn't alone. All across the city youths were customizing their names or giving themselves new ones and scrawling them across the naked city surfaces. The young graffiti writers were the advance guard of a new culture; they literally blazed trails out of the gang generation. Crossing demarcated turfs to leave their aliases in marker and spraypaint, they said "I'm here" and "Fuck all y'all" at the same time. Gang members, who had trapped themselves in their own neighborhoods, had to give them respect. Clive and the post-gang youths were a different breed, more interested in projecting individual flash than collective brawn, and they would soon render the gangs obsolete.

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Graffiti expert Jack Stewart traces the emergence of the modern-day movement to Philadelphia's neighborhoods of color as early as 1965.¹ Aerosolist and activist Steve "Espo" Powers says that the Black teenager, CORNBREAD, who is credited with popularizing the tagging of the Philly subways, was only trying to attract the attention of a beauty named Cynthia. By 1968, the movement had spread to New York City. CORNBREAD's protégé, TOP CAT, moved to Harlem and brought with him the "gangster" style of lettering. A Puerto Rican youth calling himself JULIO 204—the number was the street he hailed from—began at about the same time. When a Greek American named TAKI 183 told the *New York Times* in the summer of 1971 why he tagged his name on ice cream trucks and subway cars—"I don't feel like a celebrity normally, but the guys make me feel like one when they introduce me to someone"—thousands of New York youngsters picked up fat markers and spray paint to make their own name.² Writers like LEE 163d!, EVIL ED, CLIFF 159, JUNIOR 161, CAY 161, CHE 159 and BARBARA and EVA 62 were saying their names loud all across buildings, bus stops, and subway station walls uptown.

Roaming through gang turfs, slipping through the long arms and high fences of authority, violating notions of property and propriety, graffiti writers found their own kind of freedom. Writing your name was like locating the edge of civil society and planting a flag there. In Greg Tate's words, it was "reverse colonization."³ The 1960s, as the hip-hop generation would so often be reminded, were a great time to be young. The world seemed to shake under young feet so easily back then. The revolutionaries expected the whole world to be watching and when they were given the spotlight, they cast a long shadow. But these writers weren't like the revolutionaries, or even the philosopher-activist wall-writers in Lima, Mexico City, Paris, and Algiers. Theirs were not political statements. They were just what they were, a strike against their generation's invisibility and preparation for the coming darkness.

They held no illusions about power. No graffiti writer ever hoped to run for mayor. And unlike the gang bangers, none would submerge his or her name to the collective. They were doing it to be known amongst their peers, to be recognized for their originality, bravado, daring, and style. Norman Mailer, one of the first to write seriously about graffiti, got it instantly: the writers were composing advertisements for themselves.

In the summer of 1970, TAKI 183's tags seemed to explode across the city. Like thousands of other kids, Clive, Jerome and their friend Richard picked up markers and spraycans. Rich became UNCLE RICH, Jerome became YOGI and Clive became CLYDE AS KOOL.⁴

"They couldn't recall my name Clive," he says. "So the closest you could come was Clyde, from the Knicks basketball player. They'd be like, 'You mean like 'Clyde' Frazier?' 'Yeah. Clyde. Let's leave it like that.' So I started to write that. And where I picked 'Kool' from was this TV cigarette commercial. A guy was driving one of them Aston-Martins, like this James Bond car, and his cigarette was right there by the gear shift, white gloves, dark glasses and just driving through the countryside—whoooooooo! The girl with him, she reached over to touch his cigarette; and he goes—rrrrrrrrnt! Stops the car, leans over, opens the door, points his finger, tells her, 'Get out!' And she got out. And the commercial said, 'Nobody touches my silver-thin.' I was like, wow, that's 'Kool'! So I picked KOOL.

"Wherever you see UNCLE RICH, you see CLYDE AS KOOL," he says. "I put a little smiling face in it, the eyes, the nose, and mouth and a little cigarette hanging out, and a little tam on it, like a little Apple Jack's hat."

Writing brought him into contact with the premier stylists, and he began hanging out with the EX-VANDALS, the legendary supercrew that had begun in Brooklyn and now included SUPER KOOL 223, EL MARKO, STAY HIGH 149 and PHASE 2. As graffiti moved off the walls and onto the subway steel, EL MARKO and SUPER KOOL revolutionized the name game by painting top-to-bottom masterpieces on the train-cars in late 1971 and early 1972. Just as city officials enacted the first in what would become decades of increasingly severe anti-graffiti laws, the great Bronx writer PHASE 2 launched a series of next evolutionary steps, introducing ever more imaginative refinements on the rolling steel canvases.

But Clive would finally make his name elsewhere. He was running track, pushing weights, playing rough schoolyard basketball. His classmates kidded him, dubbing him "Hercules" for his bullish power drives to the hoop. "I went back to the block and I said, 'Yo fellas, this guy at school, man, he's calling me Hercules. I know he means well, but I don't like it.' So I said, 'What's the shortening for Hercules?' They said 'Herc.' Aaaaaah—sounds unique! So I said, 'Yo

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man, just call me Herc, leave off the 'lees', just call me Herc.' Between high school and the block, I put the two names together and I dropped the CLYDE. I started calling myself Kool Herc, and that was it."

New Fires

A fire sent the Campbells out of their Tremont apartment. Their baby brother was striking matches, lighting pieces of paper and tossing them out the window. A breeze caught a burning paper and blew it back in, setting the window curtains aflame. Although the firemen were able to put it out without anyone getting hurt, Cindy remains angry at what happened afterward. "When the fire department came in there, they were looking for money. The fire was really in one room, but in the bedroom the drawers were pulled out. My father had a tin-pan of quarters that he was saving, and that tin-pan had at least three- or four-hundred dollars in quarters at the time. That was just missing," she says.

Populations were in flux. Whites were leaving for Co-op City and the suburbs. With government vouchers and assistance money, the Campbells joined the Black and brown exodus into the West Bronx. They moved into the Concourse Plaza Hotel on the Grand Concourse at 161st Street, where many burned-out families had been temporarily relocated.

After the family moved into a brand new apartment building at 1520 Sedgwick, Kool Herc would return to the hotel to frequent the disco downstairs, the Plaza Tunnel. A friend of his from high school named Shaft spun records there, as well as a DJ named John Brown. In gay and Black clubs at the time, DJs were pushing the emerging four-on-the-floor disco beat. But the Plaza Tunnel DJs had a rawer sound. John Brown "was the first to play records like 'Give it Up or Turn it Loose' by James Brown and 'Get Ready' by Rare Earth," pioneering hip-hop journalist Steven Hager wrote. "['Get Ready'] was a favorite in the Bronx because it lasted over twenty-one minutes, which was long enough for the serious dancers to get into the beat. They loved to wait for the song's two-minute drum solo to show their most spectacular moves."⁵

The dance styles began as elaborations of moves people had seen James Brown doing on TV. Zulu Nation DJ Jazzy Jay, who began as a b-boy says, "You could be dancing with your girl and spin away from her, hit the ground, come back up. It was all about 'smooth.' Like how James used to slide across the

floor and the fancy footwork and all of that." They even called it—a hard-won irony—"burning."

James Brown's career had peaked in the late 1960s with the Black Power Movement. He performed "Say it Loud (I'm Black and I'm Proud)" without apology on national television, and his mere presence in town, it was said, prevented riots in racially tense Boston in the immediate aftermath of Martin Luther King, Jr.'s assassination.

But during the early 1970s, attitudes changed. Across the country, Black mayors took over in cities that had once burned, class gaps widened and Black radio shifted to the tastes of upwardly mobile listeners. Coleman Young became mayor of Motown, while Berry Gordy departed for Hollywood. James Brown's career went into steep decline.

Bronx-born hip-hop historian Davey D recalls, "If you listened to the Black radio station at the time, WBLS—Black-owned, Black-run, the station that everyone listened to—you did not hear James Brown. Not even at nighttime. So while James Brown was being tossed out, we were embracing him."⁶ His music, dance and style now possessed outlaw appeal. At the climax of a Plaza Tunnel night, when DJ John Brown put on "Soul Power," Hager says Black Spades would overrun the floor, hollering "Spade Power!" The firecracker energy being generated at the Plaza Tunnel gave Herc the standard to aim for with his own parties.

The Man with the Master Plan

At the same time, discos were shutting down and house parties were declining, partly because gangs like the Spades were making them unsafe. But the West Bronx had not suffered the same kind of devastation as the South Bronx. And all these youths needed somewhere to party. These reasons may explain why Sedgwick Avenue was ripe for a fresh new party scene.

The crowds at the Campbells' early Sedgwick parties were mainly high school students who were too young or too clean or living too far west to fall under the waning influence of the gangs. In those days, Herc would tell the weed-smokers to head around the block, and he'd even play slow jams. "Now and then a mom or pop might come in to see what's going on," says Herc.

Cindy adds, "My father was always there. People knew him in the neighborhood and they respected him so we never had violence or anything like that.

We didn't have to hire security guards. We never searched people. When people came, they came out of respect. It was a recreation thing for them to meet people. A lot of people met their boyfriends or girlfriends there."

Buzz spread about the back-to-school party, and they found themselves throwing parties almost on a monthly basis at the rec room. "Herc actually took away a lot of house parties and basement parties," says Cindy. "At those house parties, after a while, the parents would come in, flick on the lights and tell you, 'You kids got to get out' or 'Too many people in here' or 'I don't know who this one is' and 'Who's this burning up my floor with the cigarettes?' People didn't want to go back to that anymore."

Herc's reputation spread along the Bronx high-school circuit as well, after Cindy, through her role in student body government at Dodge High School, secured a successful boat cruise dance. By the summer of 1974, when Herc was playing regular parties to a loyal following, he decided to play a free party on the block. "And after the block party," he says, "we couldn't come back to the rec room."

Outdoors, he knew he was putting the sound system at risk, and that fights could potentially break out. "So when I come out there, I said, 'Listen. The first discrepancy, I'm pulling the plug. Let's get that straight right now. There's kids out here, there's grown folks out here and we're gonna have a good time. So anybody start anything any disturbance or any discrepancy, any beef, I'm pulling the plug because I'm not gonna be here for the repercussions. All right?' So they said, 'All right, Herc, no problem.' And I start playing for the older heads, and then I go on for the younger heads and I'll go back and forth like that," he says. "We broke daylight. I played to the next morning."

Herc wanted to summon the same kind of excitement he felt as a pickney down yard. Along with his immigrant friend Coke La Rock, he distinguished their crew from the disco DJs by translating the Kingstonian vibe of sound system DJs like Count Machuki, King Stitt, U-Roy and Big Youth for the Bronxites. Herc hooked up his mics to a Space Echo box, yard dance style. They set off their dances by giving shout-outs and dropping little rhymes. They developed their own slang. At an after-hours spot Herc spun at, a drunken regular greeted his friends with the call: "To my mellow! My mellow is in the house!" With lines like these, the two created larger-than-life personas.

Herc carefully studied the dancers. "I was smoking cigarettes and I was wait-

ing for the records to finish. And I noticed people was waiting for certain parts of the record," he says. It was an insight as profound as Ruddy Redwood's dub discovery. The moment when the dancers really got wild was in a song's short instrumental break, when the band would drop out and the rhythm section would get elemental. Forget melody, chorus, songs—it was all about the groove, building it, keeping it going. Like a string theorist, Herc zeroed in on the fundamental vibrating loop at the heart of the record, the break.

He started searching for songs by the sound of their break, songs that he would make into his signature tunes: the nonstop conga epics from The Incredible Bongo Band called "Apache" and "Bongo Rock," James Brown's "live" version of "Give It Up Turn It Loose" from the *Sex Machine* album, Johnny Pate's theme to *Shaft in Africa*, Dennis Coffey's "Scorpio"—Black soul and white rock records with an uptempo, often Afro-Latinized backbeat.⁷ Then he soaked off the labels, Jamaican style. "My father said, 'Hide the name of your records because that's how you get your rep. That's how you get your clientele.' You don't want the same people to have your same record down the block," Herc says. Here was one source of hip-hop's competitive ethic and beat-this aesthetic.

In a technique he called "the Merry-Go-Round," Herc began to work two copies of the same record, back-cueing a record to the beginning of the break as the other reached the end, extending a five-second breakdown into a five-minute loop of fury, a makeshift version excursion. Before long he had tossed most of the songs, focusing on the breaks alone. His sets drove the dancers from climax to climax on waves of churning drums. "And once they heard that, that was it, wasn't no turning back," Herc says. "They always wanted to hear breaks after breaks after breaks after breaks."

To accommodate larger crowds, Herc moved his parties further up Sedgwick Avenue into Cedar Park. He had seen construction workers hooking up power by tapping the lightposts, and so he started doing the same. "I had a big Mackintosh amp. That thing cost a lot of money and it pumped a lot of juice. It was 300 watts per channel. As the juice start coming, man, the lights start dimming. And the turntables, I had the Technics 1100A, the big ones, so it wouldn't turn." Finally they found a tool shed in the park. They would send a young boy through the stone-broken window to plug into enough juice for the sound system.

The results shocked the borough, and brought in new audiences. Aaron

Can't Stop Won't Stop

O'Bryant, who would later become DJ AJ, was a marijuana dealer living near St. Mary's Park. "Everyone was talking about this guy DJ Kool Herc. And I was really excited. I knew all the women was gonna be there. I was excited by Herc but I really wanted to see could I bag something!" he laughs. "I became a Kool Herc freak. Everywhere he played I was there."

A teen from Fox Street in the South Bronx named Joseph Saddler, who called himself Flash, also heard about Herc's exploits and went up to Cedar Park to see it for himself. "I seen this big six-foot-plus guy with this incredible sound system, heavily guarded. People just enjoying themselves from like four years to forty. I'm like, wow! He looked sort of like this superhero on this podium playing this music that wasn't being played on the radio. I liked what he was doing and what he was playing, and I wanted to do that, too."

The gangs were dissolving and Herc was popularizing a new hierarchy of cool. Turfs were still important but in a different way. Jazzy Jay says, "Instead of gangs, they started turning into little area crews where they would do a little bit of dirt. In every area, there would be a DJ crew or a breakdance crew. They would be like, 'Okay, we all about our music and we love our music but you come in this area wrong and we all about kicking your ass.' Competition fueled the whole thing."

Herc's parties drew in the crews, gave them a chance to strut their stuff and make their names. He kept the peace by taking a live-and-let-live policy and skillfully working the mic. "Everybody had to make money, even the stick-up kids. The guy selling weed would come to me, 'A-yo Herc, man, say I got weed.' I'd say, 'You know I can't say you got weed!' So I'd say it indirectly, 'Yo, Johnny, you know I can't say you got weed, right?' He'd take the heat."

"Or if I know there's a certain party up in there starting trouble, I never would say their name, I just say, 'Yo kill it, cut the bullshit out. You're my man, cut the dumb shit. You know and they know who I'm talking about. Okay? Alright.' They'd be like 'Oh shit, Herc gave me a little warning.' I might be playing music but I'm no sucker."

The real action was in the dance ciphers, with the kids who had come for Herc's "Merry-Go-Round," and were becoming personalities in their own right. They were too excitable and had too much flavor to conform to the precision group steps of dances like The Hustle. They would simply jump in one after an-

other to go off, take each other out, just "break" wild on each other. Herc called them break boys, b-boys for short.⁸

There was Tricky, Wallace Dee, the Amazing Bobo, Sau Sau, Charlie Rock, Norm Rockwell, Eldorado Mike, and Keith and Kevin, the Nigger Twins. They did dances like The Boyoing, where a b-boy sported a Turbans-like pom-pom topped hat, and stretched, wiggled, and shook back and forth to make the ball go "boyoing." "It was called that because that's basically what they see," says Jazzy Jay, "just bounce all over the place, hit the ground, go down. It wasn't like a lot of the acrobatics. It was more from style and finesse. You could do a whole routine standing up before you even hit the ground."

"Another kid uptown called it the cork-and-screw," says Jeffrey "DOZE" Green, a Rock Steady Crew member and second-generation b-boy who first saw The Boyoing in the North Bronx in 1975. "It's 'cause they used to spin down, pop up, do a split and then go whoop! Come up, and then go down again into a split into a few baby-rocks into a little baby freeze. People were spinning on their butts then, too."

"Tricky had a huge afro," says Cindy. "And he had that soft hair because his hair grew. And he did a move where he would jump up and his afro would start to bounce also. There was also a move called the Frankenstein move, where he'd start moving like Frankenstein and his afro would start bouncing. It was like a show, you know?"

Herc assembled his own clique of DJs, dancers and rappers, and dubbed them the Herculords: Coke La Rock, DJ Timmy Tim with Little Tiny Feet, DJ Clark Kent the Rock Machine, the Imperial JC, Blackjack, LeBrew, Pebblee Poo, Sweet and Sour, Prince, and Whiz Kid. He refused to call them a crew. "That name 'crew' took the place of gang. When they said, 'crew', we knew it was a gang. So it was never the Herculord crew. That's what people start calling us. But we never had on our flier saying 'The Herculord crew.' It was billed with the sound system we called the Herculoids."

After reinvesting his money in a few different sound system sets, Herc was ready to take it to the next level. By 1975, he was doing all-ages dances at the Webster Avenue P.A.L. But he was turning twenty, and didn't only want the kiddie crowd anymore. He found a club called the Twilight Zone on Jerome Avenue near Tremont, and started hosting parties there with his clique and his

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sound system. He says he screened Muhammad Ali videos until they said, "Yo Herc, stop showing them Ali fights, you souping them motherfuckers up!"

At a hot spot called the Hevalo, he passed out flyers for his Twilight Zone shows until he was chased out. One day, he vowed, I'll play this spot. On a stormy night, Herc emptied the Hevalo by playing a party at the Zone. "Rain," he says, "was a good sign for me." The Hevalo owner quickly called him up to make a deal. Soon, Herc was playing there and at another club called the Executive Playhouse for a full-fledged adult crowd.

They came to hear Herc rap: "You never heard it like this before, and you're back for more and more and more of this here rock-ness. 'Cause you see, we rock with the rockers, we jam with the jammers, we party with the partyers. Young lady don't hurt nobody. It ain't no fun till we all get some. Don't hurt nobody, young lady!"

Coke and another crew member named Dickey let the crowds know: "There's no story can't be told, there's no horse can't be rode, a no bull can't be stopped and ain't a disco we can't rock. Herc! Herc! Who's the man with a master plan from the land of Gracie Grace? Herc Herc!"

By 1976, he was the number-one draw in the Bronx. No more roach killers. DJ Kool Herc dressed the role, sporting fabulous Lee or AJ Lester suits. All the high rollers, bank robbers, and hustlers from Harlem were coming up to see him. He says, "The reputation was, 'Who is making money up in the Bronx? Kool Herc and the guy Coke La Rock with the music.'"

Two Sevens Redub

1977 started off very well for Herc. But as it would be everywhere, trouble was ahead.

It was not, as many well-meaning journalists and academics would later erroneously write, that the block party or sound system showdown had replaced the rumble or the riot. That notion was as misguided as Robert Moses's contention that nothing good could ever again come from the Bronx. The truth was, in fact, much less dramatic and much more profound. In the Bronx's new hierarchy of cool, the man with the records had replaced the man with the colors. Violence did not suddenly end; how could it? But an enormous amount of creative energy was now ready to be released from the bottom of American society, and

Making a Name

the staggering implications of this moment eventually would echo around the world.

By 1977, Herc and his competitors had divided the Bronx into a new kind of grid. In the South Bronx from 138th to 163rd streets, where the Bachelors, the Savage Nomads, the Savage Skulls and the Ghetto Brothers had once run, Grandmaster Flash, backed by the local Casanova Crew, was emerging as the area celebrity. In the Southeast, formerly the territory of the Black Spades, P.O.W.E.R. and the Javelins, Afrika Bambaataa held sway with his Zulu Nation. In the north, there was DJ Breakout and DJ Baron. And the West Bronx neighborhood and the East Bronx nightclubs were still Herc's. Herc remained the undisputed king of the borough by virtue of his records, his loyal crowd, and his sound system.

"It was ridiculous. He was god," says Zulu Nation DJ Jazzy Jay. At a legendary Webster P.A.L. contest, Herc drowned out Bambaataa's system with little effort. "Whenever Kool Herc played outside, shit was loud and crystal clean. When we'd play outside, we'd be hooking up a whole bunch of little wires, a bunch of four or five amps and—errnt! Zzzzt! Shit would be blowing up." And every time Grandmaster Flash came to a Herc party, Flash chuckles, "Herc always used to embarrass me."

After being threatened by some cops for his drug selling, Herc's fan Aaron O'Bryant moved on to promoting parties. He rented the Savoy Manor nightclub on 149th Street and the Grand Concourse. "I wanted to have Kool Herc versus Pete DJ Jones. Back then Pete DJ Jones was number one on the disco set and Kool Herc was just number one, period," he recalls. "So I had a commitment from Pete DJ Jones because he was a businessman, he took on all bookings. The first thing Kool Herc wanted to know was where did I get his telephone number from. And he was explaining to me that I was not a proven promoter. Plus, he also insinuated that he could go to the Savoy Manor and rent it himself and do that battle if he wanted. He didn't want to let me eat."

By the end of the spring, Herc noticed his audiences were declining. "People are getting older now, it wasn't all about me. All of a sudden now you're not eighteen no more, you're twenty-four and twenty-five. You can drink now. You ain't coming to no little seventeen-, eighteen-year-old party," he recalls. "And other people was coming up."

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After the blackout and the looting, there were plenty of new crews with brand new sound systems in the streets, and Herc's main rivals were luring away his crowd. Flash had precision, sophistication and an entertainer's flair. Bambaataa had his records and the power of Bronx River behind him. O'Bryant himself had begun DJing. As DJ AJ, he teamed with a new turntable tutor, Lovebug Starski, and expanded into Harlem. Herc says, "I stayed behind, I didn't move with them to downtown. I stayed up in the Bronx."

Herc finally agreed to play with DJ AJ at a back-to-school party at the Executive Playhouse. It was sold out, AJ recalls, but Herc was no longer the main draw. "Flash was at my show. I let Flash get on and I let Melle Mel get on the mic," AJ says. "But it didn't help Herc's career at all because he was fading fast."

A few months later, Herc was preparing for another night at the Playhouse, now renamed The Sparkle, when he heard a scuffle breaking out. "Mike-With-The-Lights had a discrepancy with somebody at the door," Herc recalls. Mike was refusing to allow three men into the club and they had become increasingly agitated. When Herc went to mediate the situation, one of the men drew a knife. Herc felt it pierce him three times in the side. As he put his bloodied hand up to block his face, the attacker stabbed him once more in the palm before disappearing with the others up the stairs and into the night. "It made me draw back into a little shell," Herc says, exhaling for a long moment.

It was 1977.

Bob Marley was in a foreign studio, recovering from an assassin's ambush and singing: "Many more will have to suffer. Many more will have to die. Don't ask me why." Bantu Stephen Biko was shackled, naked and comatose in the back of a South African police Land Rover. The Baader-Meinhof gang lay in suicide pools in a German prison. The Khmer Rouge filled their killing fields. The Weather Underground and the Young Lords Party crawled toward the final stages of violent implosion. In London, as in New York City, capitalism's crisis left entire blocks and buildings abandoned, and the sudden appearance of pierced, mohawked, leather-jacketed punks on Kings Road set off paroxysms of hysteria. History behaved as if reset to year zero.

In the Bronx, Herc's time was passing. But the new culture that had arisen around him had captured the imagination of a new breed of youths in the Bronx.

Herc had stripped down and let go of everything, save the most powerful basic elements—the rhythm, the motion, the voice, the name. In doing so, he summoned up a spirit that had been there at Congo Square and in Harlem and on Wareika Hill. The new culture seemed to whirl backward and forward—a loop of history,

Rapture in Reagan's America

The room was hot, sweaty, highly charged and had the feel of destiny to it.

—Chi Chi Valenti

You just had the sense of the future, like you could do anything you wanted to.

—Ruza "Kool Lady" Blue

It was morning in Ronald Reagan's bright white America. Elected by a landslide in 1980, he rode into office like a celluloid cavalry colonel coming to the rescue of the beleaguered frontiersmen. When Reagan's campaign trail took him through the dead land of Fort Apache to Charlotte Street, it followed almost exactly the same route that Jimmy Carter had taken in 1977. There, Carter had given his soundbite: "I'm impressed by the spirit of hope and determination by the people to save what they have." Three years later, on the same empty block, the only things new were John Fekner's graffiti stencils on the blasted brick walls, which read: FALSAS PROMESAS and BROKEN PROMISES. Reagan stopped in front of one of these stencilled walls, to the eternal grief of his handlers and positioners, and told the media: "I'm impressed with the spirit of hope and determination by the people to save what they have."¹ The presidential campaign had become a nitrate film, looping in advanced decomposition.

In downtown's tiny art-crammed sweatboxes, whites were watching young brown and Black b-boys go off to throbbing Afro-Latinized versions of soundtrack music from the spaghetti westerns often played by mixed-race bands like

the Incredible Bongo Band's "Apache" and Babe Ruth's "The Mexican," dramatic rewrites of Ennio Morricone themes that the b-boys favored for their head-bursting percussion, thundering basslines and Morricone's cascading, whooping melodies. In particular, "The Mexican," sung by Jenny Haan, captured the fall of the Alamo through the eyes of a Mexican *bandito* caught on the American side when the fighting commenced. It climaxed with a final battle cry: "Morning, sad morning, heaven will be there!"

Downtown Utopia

The nightclub had become a communal sacred space, a chance to escape the chafing oppression of time, to vault the restrictions of the social order, a place to watch the rules become liquid, and peer into possibility.

In the body heat and thumping beats, Ruza Blue, a true believer in the power of clubbing, was seeking a sensual utopia and a democratic alternative. "It was the Reagan era and there was talk of war and nuclear weapons," she says. "But then there was this whole thing going on in New York where it was the youth culture getting together in unity and peace and having fun. No segregation and everyone joining together. Just the opposite of what was going on politically."

And Crazy Legs, a true believer in the power of hip-hop, saw what many others saw—a bit of magic happening. "It was the beginning of the breaking down of racial barriers," he says, "'82 was the beginning of worldwide understanding." But there would be a price to pay, too. They were promised heavens—false heavens and heavens which never materialized. The nights of radiant children always came to an end.

When spring bloomed in 1981, the giddy affair between uptown and downtown topped the charts. Deborah Harry—who, by the number of canvases dedicated to her, seemed to be the object of every graffiti artist's desire—was sweetly sighing out of every radio in the country: "Wall to wall, people hypnotized, and they're stepping lightly, hang each night in rapture." Then she turned sly, and rapped: "FAB 5 FREDDY told me everybody's fly, DJ's spinning I said, 'My, my!' Flash is fast, Flash is cool. *Francois c'est pas flashe non deux.*" Not that anyone outside of New York—least of all Paris—knew what she was talking about. Not yet.

The rapture was still mainly in the minds of the believers, a small tribe moving

to the edge of reshaping pop culture. Ruza Blue, a recent immigrant from London, was one of the believers. By day, she ran World's End, Vivienne Westwood and Malcolm McLaren's Soho boutique. In London, she had been a regular at a landmark new wave club run by Steve Strange called The Blitz. She recalls, "I used to go down there every Tuesday night to the club, sometimes not even getting in because sometimes Steve wouldn't let you in. I used to stand outside, 'Please let me in!' And I thought one day, I'm gonna do a club like this. I don't know what I'm going to put inside it, but I'm gonna do something like that." After she saw Bambaataa and the Rock Steady Crew open for Bow Wow Wow at the Ritz, she knew she had found religion. She began frequenting the Disco Fever with FAB 5 FREDDY, who dubbed her "Kool Lady Blue."

By November, Blue started hosting her own Thursday night "Wheels of Steel" parties at a tiny basement reggae club—capacity: 200—called Negril. Once frequented by Bob Marley, Negril had become the after-hours hangout for the Clash and other Brit punk expats. With Michael Holman, she brought in what seemed to have become the party-starting bill of the year: Bambaataa and the Zulu Nation DJs, FAB 5 FREDDY, RAMMELLZEE and the Rock Steady Crew. Then she promoted it to her punk peers, "People heard, 'Oh wow, the Clash are hanging out there.' " When they arrived, they encountered iconic Bronx b-boys hanging outside in kangols, ski goggles, and bubble jackets, and inside, a racially mixed crowd who had cleared a circle for the Rock Steady Crew and were moving to the sounds of Bambaataa, Jazzy Jay and Afrika Islam on the turntables and FAB 5 FREDDY on the microphone.

Blue's "Wheels of Steel" night at Negril was the next logical step from FAB's "Beyond Words" show at the Mudd Club, Henry Chalfant's abortive Common Ground show, and the revived "Graffiti Rock" shows with FAB and The Rock Steady Crew and a host of graf artists at the Kitchen. Jazzy Jay says, "First couple times we played at Negril, it was an a-ight crowd, not too many people was in there. By the time a couple of weeks went by, man, it was standing room only!"

The tiny club hummed with sensory overload. Jorge "Popmaster Fabel" Pabon, who was initiated into Rock Steady on the Negril dance floor, recalls, "Here we are looking at punk rockers and different types of bugged out people, you know, those Village type people. It was a whole new experience."

Negril had been a space for punks and Rastas and like-minded scenesters to meet on equal terms. Now, Blue handed the club over to the Bronx and uptown crew, and the exclusive crowd soaked up the vibe. Jazzy Jay says, "We'd school from the DJ booth, you know what I'm saying? That's what we was doing downtown. We was schooling them on our artform. Bam would put these breaks on and drive them wild and then I'd get on the turntables and start cutting shit up and they'd be losing their minds. MCs get on, that was it. B-boys take the floor, it was like, yo!"

Fabel recalls, "We fed off of the crowd a lot; to get them hyped was half of the reason we did it. Well, at least a quarter. Three-fourths were for more selfish reasons," he chuckles. "Like, there's some fine girls around here, yo!"

Jazzy Jay couldn't believe his luck either. "I'm a carpenter by trade," he says. "I'm making as much from this as I'm making from my union gig. You know what? The union gig can wait. My hobby is doing me alright." After four dazzling months, the crowds were bursting the club's walls. Fire department officials stepped in to shut Negril down. No matter. Negril would turn out to be merely a prelude.

By then, everyone was humming another downtown hit. Tom Tom Club, a lighthearted spinoff group of the heralded post-punk band Talking Heads, caught ears with "Genius of Love"—a girlish ode to the deepest, coolest guy in town that slipped, somehow appropriately, into a celebration of the Black rhythms of George Clinton, Bootsy Collins, Bohannon, Bob Marley and Sly and Robbie. The song captured the peculiarly downtown ecstasy: "There's no beginning and there is no end. Time isn't present in that dimension." By the last verse, however, it was clear that the affair—sweet as it was—was doomed.

Be What You Be

In April of 1982, Afrika Bambaataa unleashed a grand statement for what he was now calling the hip-hop movement. It was called "Planet Rock."

Bambaataa was the right man to do it. He walked through downtown the way he did in the Bronx, the warrior-king of a massive, expanding tribe. He shaved a mohawk into his head—a salute, it seemed, not only to the rebels of Kings Road and the Bowery but a young, shocking Sonny Rollins. His crew dressed like a wild cross between a band of New Orleans Mardi Gras Indians

and interstellar Afrofuturist prophets. Downtowners were impressed. "This guy carries weight," Gary Jardim wrote in *The Village Voice*, "like the music stars in the '60s did."²

After cutting two singles with Paul Winley—different versions of "Zulu Nation Throwdown" (Bambaataa says "Death Mix" was unauthorized)—and being disappointed with the results, Bambaataa met Tom Silverman, a white music journalist who had started a record label for twelve-inch dance singles.

"Bambaataa was very, very different than anybody else was from the Bronx. He said, 'I don't want to be a star because stars fall,'" Silverman recalls. "When you're in the presence of a person like that you just feel a different kind of energy. I've seen this guy when he was DJing and a fight would break out. He'd stop the music and then he'd play like four bars of James Brown and stop the music again. And he goes, 'You like that? Stop fighting.' And everyone would stop fighting and he'd turn on the music again." Silverman knew he wanted to do business with this guy.

While publishing a popular tip-sheet called *Dance Music Report*, Silverman had first heard about hip-hop music from a friend at Downstairs Records. "I knew the store because I used to buy doo-wop music there. They'd opened a new room and it was called the 'B-boy Room' and it was like a closet the size of a small office. It had a high desk in the front and in the back they had the records. It was the specialty room where you have kids come in and buy these breakbeat records.

"They were buying things like cut-out records that were like a dollar each but they were being sold for ten dollars. Albums like The Eagles' *The Long Run* and Billy Squier's "Big Beat," all these weird records! Bob James, "Apache," "Dance to the Drummer's Beat"—a lot of them on 45s, a few off albums and a lot of people would buy them just for one break and the break would only be for seven seconds long or three seconds long so they have to buy two of them so they could mix it. The kids were fifteen and sixteen. They'd chip in money, then three or four of them would come in and buy records together. I asked them how they find out about which records had the breaks, where they find out about the breaks, and they say there's this guy in the Bronx called Afrika Bambaataa and he had this thing called the Zulu Nation. So I went up to check it out."

Bambaataa was spinning at the T-Connection at a Zulu Nation anniversary

party. Red Alert and Jazzy Jay were standing sentry, handing him records. "It was the weirdest mix of music I ever heard in my life but it was amazing," says Silverman. After returning to Bam's parties a few more times, Silverman asked him if he'd like to make records. They talked for a minute, then before Silverman left Bambaataa handed him a business card that read, "Afrika Bambaataa Master of Records." Under Silverman's label, Tommy Boy, Bambaataa released "Jazzy Sensation" in November 1981.

Silverman had brought in a young dance producer named Arthur Baker to oversee "Jazzy Sensation." Baker had begun to learn how to use drum machines, synthesizers and early sampling technology. The record was a success, and the three wanted more.

By then Bambaataa had realized, "I could use my albums to send messages. And the record companies played their role of sending these messages to all these places." He told Silverman he had an idea for a song. He and Jazzy Jay had already drawn up a rough blueprint of the music, based on some of his favorite records: Babe Ruth's "The Mexican," Captain Sky's "Super Sperm," Kraftwerk's "Numbers" and "Trans-Europe Express," B.T. Express' "Do You Like It" and Rick James' "Give It to Me." Together, he and Silverman put together a rough eight-track demo on synthesizers. In the meantime, Bam went to his rapper MC GLOBE and gave him the concept to begin laying out the rap.

Bambaataa had hooked up with gearhead and keyboardist virtuoso John Robie, who had a dance single that Bam was playing. Silverman, seeing the obvious, blessed the project and sent the Bam, Baker and Robie to Vanguard Studios in the Village to assemble the record. The final version included only Kraftwerk and Babe Ruth.

This stripped-down result somehow perfectly captured Bambaataa's mystery. "Planet Rock" 's polycultural pastiche, framed by swooping, synthesized orchestral stabs, sucked the listener into another world—where dramatic melodies drifted across a barren landscape, "where the nights are hot, where nature's children dance inside a trance," where everyone could rock it, don't stop it. Not only did it sound unlike anything that had ever come out of the Bronx, it sounded unlike anything else anywhere. "Planet Rock" was hip-hop's universal invitation, a hypnotic vision of one world under a groove, beyond race, poverty, sociology and geography. The Soulsonic Force shouted, "No work or play, our world is free. Be what you be, just be!"

Bambaataa says, "I really made it for the Blacks, Latinos and the punk rockers, but I didn't know the next day that everybody was all into it and dancing. I said, 'Whoa! This is interesting.'" Silverman says that the record cost eight hundred dollars to make. It went on to sell 650,000 copies. But its importance would be felt far beyond the number of copies it sold.

"'Planet Rock' had more impact than any record I've ever been involved in," Silverman says. "The only record I can think of in the hip-hop movement that maybe had more of an impact was 'Rapper's Delight' because that's the first one that opened the door.³ But 'Planet Rock' took it in a whole 'nother way. That was the record that initiated that it wasn't just an urban thing, it was inclusive. It was okay for rockers, new wavers, uptown coming downtown. That's when they started pouring in from France and England to cover hip-hop. That's when hip-hop became global."

Street Culture's at the Roxy

When Kool Lady Blue finally found a new home for her "Wheels of Steel" night, her club became the steamy embodiment of the Planet Rock ethos. In Negril, Blue had seen the potential of a model that countered the elitism of the Blitz. To its ecstatic followers, the Roxy would become "a club that changed the world."⁴

After getting kicked out of Negril, Blue had done a couple of "Wheels of Steel" nights at Danceteria, another downtown new wave club. But convinced that she was on to something big and magnificent, she fell in love with a huge, nearly block-long roller rink in Chelsea on West 18th Street and Tenth Avenue. The Roxy's capacity was twenty times that of Negril. "I said the Roxy is mega-big, I can't see you packing that joint," says FAB 5 FREDDY. "She said, 'Well I think we have an idea, we can bring this curtain and cut off more than half of the club.' So she took me to show it to me and I gave her my thumbs up on some shit like that. Then from there it was like, boom!"

In June, Blue hung out a sign at the rink: COME IN PEACE THROUGH MUSIC. Her gamble was immaculately timed. She opened the club with all of the scene's leading lights at the beginning of a hot summer when graffiti and b-boying and hip-hop music was on everyone's minds.

For the first few nights, a curtain painted by FUTURA was set in the middle of the floor. Each week, the crowd grew and the curtain moved back toward the wall, until it was literally against the wall. Long lines snaked down West 18th to-

ward the Hudson. After clearing the bouncers, clubbers stepped up into a long hallway that featured neon-colored graf murals and felt the tricky beats set their hearts to racing. They were stepping into another world.

"The regulars were Bam and Afrika Islam, and then Grandmixer DST, Jazzy Jay, Grand Wizard Theodore, Grandmaster Flash, and I'd rotate them," she says. "We had no booth. The DJ would be in the center of the floor on a podium. Everyone could see what he was doing, and he was kind of elevated to rock star status." On both sides of the DJ, large projection screens displayed Charlie Ahearn's slides of Bronx b-boys, rappers, and scenemakers. Nearby, the Rock Steady Crew convened all-night ciphers on the beautiful blonde wood floors. PHASE 2 designed the club's flyers and he, FUTURA, DOZE and others often did graf pieces live onstage. Here were the four elements, re-presented downtown as performance art on an epic and mythic scale.

FAB 5 FREDDY recalls the turning point as the July night Blue decided to book a screening of McLaren's Sex Pistols movie, *The Great Rock 'N' Roll Swindle* before the regular opening of the club. "The crowd initially was mostly heads from the scene. The night when it all really mixed I remember vividly," he says. "[The film] attracted all of these cool punks, white new wave heads, whatever. The film was shown kinda early like around nine. When it was over, a lot of that crowd stayed. And then the crowd for the hip-hop night started to come and I was wondering like, 'Yo what's gonna happen?' And everybody kinda bugged out looking at each other. You had these ill b-boys with the poses and shit, checking out these kids with the crazy haircuts and that whole vibe. And everybody kinda got into each other, so to speak. That's when it really kinda took off as the first really major downtown club that had like a legitimately mixed scene."

The East Village elite came west—all the Mudd Club regulars, the Co-Lab activists, bands like the Talking Heads and the B-52s, the come-ups known by a singular name: Basquiat, Haring, Madonna. Blue billed it as the anti-Studio 54. But the stars came anyway, blown in by the winds of change, the promise of something ineffably new and vibrant. David Bowie and Andy Warhol descended from the VIP booth to the join the masses on the dancefloor.

The scene also felt inviting for mainstream whites, like David Hershkovits, a music journalist who would go on to publish *PAPER* magazine. "It was cool, it

wasn't rowdy. And I don't remember it smelling dangerous or anything like that, the way those things eventually turned into," he says. "What attracted me to it at first was it was a hip-hop thing coming downtown from the Bronx into my neighborhood and mingling with the artists and the writers and the people who were in Manhattan who didn't have any direct contact with hip-hop at the time. The doors were open.

"The crowds were very diverse. That was why I was so excited to be there. Suddenly this racially mixed group was having a good time partying in a room together, which was a very rare thing. On the level of music and art, people were able to bridge all these boundaries."

He adds, "The other thing that reminds me of those days is the style, because we were coming out of a sloppy era. Punk rock was about wearing torn clothes, T-shirts and just messy. Here you got these guys who would wear their jeans, but they'd be creased and they'd be perfect. And they'd have their sneakers but they'd be completely white. I remember one time I went into the bathroom and I said, 'What are you doing?' And it was FAB 5 FREDDY and another guy with toothbrushes cleaning their shoes. Here were these guys from the ghettos coming out and showing everyone how to dress, how to be fresh, how to be clean, how to have it together—whether it was the way you did your dance or your graffiti or your rapping or your DJing, it was all style."

Among the masses on the floor were a new generation of white kids, watching the future rush right up to their shelltoes. Dante Ross, who would become a key hip-hop A & R exec during the late '80s, remembers, "I used to go to the Roxy, me and my neighbor Adrock. Me and the Beastie Boys and the girls from Luscious Jackson, we were like the handful of people who got to experience shit while it was still open and ill, before New York was corny and everything was kind of co-opted. The word 'alternative' didn't exist. It was this great moment, man, the 'Graffiti Rock' moment. Everything was all mixed up, it was cool to be eclectic." The music was uptempo, bright—Malcolm McLaren's "Buffalo Gals," Chuck Brown's "Bustin' Loose," Manu Dibango's "Soul Makossa," the Rolling Stones' "Start Me Up," Aleem's "Release Yourself," new rap records by FAB 5 FREDDY and PHASE 2—a perfect showcase for the Rock Steady.

Crazy Legs, all of sixteen, was amazed at how far he and his crew had come in three short years. "We were the stars," he says. "When we had started per-

forming, we were the people that were at the jams in the Bronx outside the ropes. Now we had become the people that were inside the ropes. Now we had the opportunity to perform with Cold Crush Brothers, Fantastic Five, Grandmaster Flash, Grandmixel D.ST., Funky Four + One, we became part of that elite clique in hip-hop. We thought about that a lot. We were just appreciating the fact that we were at a place where we could be recognized for our skills by all these people we wanted to be."

"We were just innocently having fun," he says, "not realizing that we were setting a foundation for what is a multibillion dollar a year industry."

Charlie Ahearn recalls, "You would go to a night at the Roxy and there would be eight b-boying circles. Girls would be getting laid in the back room by fourteen-year old graffiti artists that couldn't wait to do some blonde. It was all good. A lot of excitement, a lot of energy."

"Ah man, the Roxy," sighs DOZE. "Home! That's when the money was rolling and cocaine was flowing!"

"I call them Dustland Memories. Fuck Stardust memories, it's Dustland memories!" he laughs. "Just everyone being on zoo-bang, walking around with cocaine wrapped up in newspaper, and just being in the VIP room with Madonna, and Shannon and fucking Jody Watley and fucking Shalamar and all them heads. It was just funny." He shakes his head at his teen mischief, halfway between pride and sadness.

"You go from the real new waver to the hardcore punk to the b-boy to the stick-up kid b-boy to the Dale Webo fashion boy to the Funhouse Jellybean Benitez look to the Madonna lace-fiend to the wannabe artist *nouveau* bohemian. It was just an eclectic bunch. But it was cool 'cause everybody got along and you got to meet some real cool chicks. Kinda weird chicks, too. Weird weird weird weird!"

Then he becomes animated. "Crazy shit went on in that place. My mom even went! Ken Swift's mom used to go. Crazy Legs's mom used to go. Yeah! We'd be embarrassed. Like—'Ah Ma! Get outta here, come on!' 'I'm so proud of you, come here!' We'd be like, 'Fuuuuck, get outta here!' So we'd hide 'til they leave, 'cause parents have to go home early." He's laughing hard now. "They'd leave, then we'd be like, 'Yeah! Aiiight! Wassup baby!'" he laughs, making a high-five, then bending his head as if over a mirror laced with white lines. "Snnnnnoooooort! Ahhh. Aiiight!"

Chi Chi Valenti, a downtown personality and sometime host at the Roxy, wrote, "By late 1982, Fridays had become a required stop for visiting journalists and Eurotrash—to be in New York and miss the Roxy was unthinkable. More than anything the Roxy embodied a certain vision of what New York could be—a multiracial center of a world culture, running on a current of flaming, uncompromised youth."⁵

Blue tried to match all the artistic ambition with a booking policy that was just as eclectic and innovative. She brought an uptown who's-who to the downtown stage: Double Trouble, the Treacherous Three, the Fearless Four, the Disco Four, The Crash Crew, The Sequence, Masterdon and the Def Committee DJs. In the earliest stages of their careers, New Edition, Madonna and Run DMC stepped onto the Roxy stage. She brought in the Double Dutch girls, and featured a Harlem youth dance troupe and a Brazilian capoeira crew. She even hired Native Americans to perform a sundance.

But as high as the highs were, some of the hip-hop heads were beginning to wonder about what was really going on. Were they being paid fairly? Were they being exploited? Just how did this white downtown crowd really see them? Did being a part of the anti-Studio 54 only mean that the street kids got a chance to sniff coke, too?

Crazy Legs says, "The Roxy could have also been a zoo. People were able to hang out in the cage with us and feel safe from getting beat up or stuck up, as opposed to coming to the Bronx, coming to a jam. It's like they were allowed to hang out in the cage and party with the animals, you know? It was a safe haven for a lot of people. But on the flip side, it was also us getting into places that we never thought we could get into. So there was an exchange there."

He concludes, "I'm not gonna sit here and act like, 'Oh wow, it was so great back then!' There were things—that was also the beginning of us getting jerked. I'm not bitter about it. I'm over that. But that's a reality."

Close to the Edge

Outside the floating world of the Roxy, Reagan's recession had bloated unemployment levels to the highest levels since the Great Depression—30 million searching for work.⁶ The official Black unemployment rate hit 22 percent.⁷ Poverty rates were soaring too. Black poverty hit a twenty-five-year peak in 1983, with 36 percent of the population counted as living below the poverty

level. It was much worse for young people. One estimate was that only one in five New York City teens had a job, only one in ten African Americans, the lowest ratios of youth employment in the country.⁸

After dark, DJs cut up Trouble Funk's "Pump Me Up," with its ironic command for people to dance their troubles away: "All we want to see is your body work!" But the Roxy night always opened into a Reagan morning that was much more than a comedown. "The Message," released just weeks after the Roxy opened, was a downtempo track that perfectly captured that after-dawn crash when the buzz wore off.

It was credited to Grandmaster Flash and the Furious Five, but the story behind that naming revealed other tensions as well. The song was a home-studio concoction of Sugar Hill songwriter and house band percussionist Ed "Duke Bootee" Fletcher, featuring a memorable synthesizer hook from Jiggs Chase, that seemed to bear the influence of Peter Tosh's "Stepping Razor" and Black Uhuru's *Red*. Bootee and Sugar Hill mogul Sylvia Robinson could not interest Flash in recording it. He and the rappers felt the song had no energy, that the lyrics would get them booed offstage by their hardcore fans. You went to a party to forget about shit like this.

But Robinson and Bootee recorded the track anyway, peeling off Furious Five rapper Melle Mel to add his last verse from a forgotten version of "Superappin'." Robinson decided "The Message" had to be released as a single. Flash saw where this was going, and he pushed the rest of the Five into the studio to try to rap Bootee's lines. It didn't work. Instead, Bootee and Robinson added them at the end of the record, in streetside arrest skit recalling Stevie Wonder's interlude in "Living for the City." But Pandora's Box had been opened. The ensuing tug-of-wars between the group and the label and between Mel and Flash resulted in Flash leaving Sugar Hill the following year. The video appeared, with Flash and the crew lip-synching along to a rap only Mel had helped compose.

Sugar Hill's second most important rap record had been as A&R-driven and market-driven as its first, and the consequences for hip-hop music were also far-reaching. Not only was "The Message" another boost for the rapper over the DJ, the crew itself became a dramatic casualty of rap's realignment towards copyrights, trademarks, executives, agents, lawyers and worldwide audiences. By the end of 1983, there were two groups called the Furious Five, competing

in civil court for the rights to the name, and dousing their creative fires under thousands of dollars of cocaine. From this point, questions of ownership and authorship would become hip-hop generation obsessions.

But Robinson's instincts had been exactly right: the record became the fifth rap single to reach gold-selling status. The single certainly did not represent the first time post-'60s rappers had chosen to touch on themes of social dislocation and institutional racism—Kurtis Blow's "The Breaks," "Hard Times" and "Tough," Brother D and the Collective Effort's "How We Gonna Make the Black Nation Rise," and Tanya "Sweet Tee" Winley's "Vicious Rap" were just some of the recorded examples. But because it was set to a beat too slow to rock a crowd, "The Message" focused the listener on Bootee and Mel's vivid lyrics and their delivery—neither frenetic nor flamboyant, but instead, by turns, resigned and enraged. Flash's instincts had been correct, too: it was the grimmest, most down-beat rap ever heard.

And that vibe matched a rising disgust with Reaganomics, the culmination of fifteen years of benign neglect, and a sense of hopelessness that only seemed to be deepening. Liberal music critics who had been sitting on the fence about rap jumped off with both feet. "[I]t's been awfully easy to criticize mainstream, street-level rap for talking loud and saying nothing. No more," wrote Vince Aletti in *The Village Voice*, praising the song's chorus as "a slow chant seething with desperation and fury," and the track's "exhilarating, cinematic sprawl."⁹

It's among hip-hop history's greatest ironies that "The Message," so artificial and marginal by the standards of the culture then, would prove at once to be a song so truthful about the generation's present and, in its righteous retail math, so influential to that generation's future culture.

Fun and Guns

The visions of "Planet Rock"—universal communion and transcendence—and "The Message"—ghetto strife and specificity—could only be brought together on the dance floor. But in the graffiti movement, both a bellwether and a vanguard, the contradictions were intensifying. Mike "IZ THE WIZ" Martin, a king from Queens, says, "1982, in my opinion, was the beginning of the end for graffiti. That's why I did as many pieces as I could during that time period. I knew it was the last hurrah."

Dondi White, for instance, had made his legend during the blackout of 1977. When the next summer morning came, the sixteen-year old's name had been emblazoned over a staggering number of cars and he had begun his journey toward becoming the Stylemaster General.¹⁰ Five years later, he was leaving the subway underworld for the light of the galleries—a carnival of openings, meetings, contracts, exhibitions. On Valentine's Day in 1982, he opened his first solo show at the dizzying, packed Fun Gallery.

The public face of the Fun Gallery was its magnetic co-director, Patti Astor, a '68er, sometime Warhol associate, and a former underground movie star, who had just finished a role in *Wild Style* playing a journalist who brings the hip-hop scene downtown. Her tiny storefront in the East Village became a more traditional gallery counterpart to the Bronx's freewheeling Fashion Moda. It was a downtown lodestar from which a shortlist of writers could catapult themselves into the art scene.

When it opened in August of 1981, it was a temporary space with no name. The artists would give it one when they showed there. "Kenny Scharf came up with 'Fun Gallery,' FAB FIVE FREDDY was next. He wanted to call it 'The Serious Gallery,'" Astor said. "We stayed with 'Fun.'" ¹¹ FAB's show vaulted the gallery into the international spotlight. The East Village, once needle-stick somnambulant, was suddenly fun. At its peak, it featured over seventy galleries.¹²

There was a growing duality in the movement. Some writers called the galleries their new yard. But they would never master the art-world the way they had their world of yards and transit cops, toys and enemies. Years later, Elizabeth Hess would ask the question that was never answered at the time, "Was it their work or their class and racial exoticism that inspired patrons to support them and dealers to legitimize their unorthodox talents?"¹³

"Between '82 and '85 I created enough work to supply ten dealers in five galleries," Dondi told ZEPHYR. "The thing is, I felt if I wasn't painting then people would think I wasn't a real artist to begin with."¹⁴ Collectors dabbling in graffiti as radical chic wrapped the artists in an unfamiliar, uncomfortable strait-jacket of preconceptions and expectations.

It was becoming clear to the artists that while the biggest galleries were eager to make stars of Haring and Basquiat and Scharf, they saw the artists

from the subways as a bunch of primitives. ZEPHYR says, "One thing that always comes back in my mind is that CRASH, FUTURA—totally different artists, completely different aesthetics visually—all were struggling with the fact that the people who were presenting this work were often unwilling or unable to present those artists as individuals with a very distinct vision. Every artist had their own thing visually. But it didn't come out because very few of the dealer/owners, with a few exceptions, had the willingness to avoid group shows."

In 1981, the group shows had been a way for the smaller galleries to make their name and for marginal artists to join together to administer the shock of the new. By 1983, group shows were another form of marginalization. And even as the slightly tipsy art-world toasted itself in opening itself to ghetto youths, the subway and street graf scene was undergoing an explosion of violence it had never seen before.

Mayor Ed Koch and the MTA's Richard Ravitch militarized the yards with \$20 million worth of razor-wire fences and guard dogs. The cars were white-washed, turned into "The Great White Fleet," and the MTA shifted its strategy towards defending the clean cars. Suddenly the amount of painting space dropped.

This problem was exacerbated by all of the media attention. At the same time, Chalfant's and Cooper's photos, the anti-graffiti campaigns, the TV shows, the magazine articles and the gallery buzz swirled into a mega-TAKI effect. In the past when a young toy was seen in the yard, he would be carrying the paint-bag of a master. Now IZ was finding himself face to face in the yards with packs of thirty and forty little kids, descending in clouds of noise, hitting him up to tag their piece books, leaving empty cans all over the place, always setting off cop raids.

With the buff and the toy flood, a new breed of bombers took over. IZ says, "One of the cardinal rules of graffiti was you didn't go over somebody. And if you did, you made sure it was very clear it wasn't a dis. Like if somebody had a throw-up, you did a whole car and naturally you buried it, so it wasn't disrespectful." Now, as Chalfant and Silver would document in their brilliant documentary *Style Wars*, bombers like CAP ONE could overturn that rule. When the masterpieces were erased, the definition of fame changed,

the underlying structure of respect collapsed and graffiti's code of conduct unraveled.

To CAP, the distinction between his throw-up and your piece was meaningless. If you went over him, he was going to go over you—everywhere, he emphasized. He began attacking on multiple fronts. These cross-outs weren't, like Basquiat's, for play, they were for blood.

There had always been beatdowns, but now crews mobilized to defend themselves and their spaces, and more consciously and viciously policed their layups and yards. The beefs sometimes spilled into block parties and neighborhood jams. There was, SPAR ONE says, "a whole war mentality. That's when I remember things started getting really violent."

At the High School of Art and Design, PINK curated a graffiti-art exhibit with twenty of the school's best writers. She recalls, "We had a wonderful exhibit with canvases and big eight-foot panels, free standing, and illustrations and black books and the works. We had everything in glass cases, hung up. All in all, it was a successful opening and I went home at three that afternoon, I was all exhausted. And I catch my exhibit on the six o'clock news.

"Apparently CAP and PJAY showed up, pulled out a .45 and shot my school full of holes. Shot one kid in the back. That was it. They closed the show the next day and the principal requested I just leave their school. I never graduated from the High School of Art and Design and the faculty really cracked down on graffiti writers after that."

Graffiti was caught between acceptance and rebellion, aspiration and motivation. IZ says, "It was getting to a point where beef was getting settled at gallery shows, because you couldn't find them anywhere else."

A World Tour

At the same time, the four elements were being packaged to tour for the first time outside of New York. As a measure of how big hip-hop was dreaming, the tour would bypass America and head straight for the Old World. In November, Kool Lady Blue sent the stars of the Roxy to tour England and France.

Organized by French journalist and indie record label owner Bernard Zekri, the bill was headlined by Afrika Bambaataa and the Soulsonic Force, and included the Rock Steady Crew, the World Champion Fantastic Four Double Dutch

girls, FUTURA, DONDI, Grandmixer D.ST. and the Infinity Rappers, RAMMELLZEE and FAB 5 FREDDY.

FAB recalls, "Heads were like, 'Yo, what's our show gon' be, what we gon' do?' I thought about it, I said, 'Let me just tell you. Look, being that I got an art background I done seen some weird shit on the performance art tip. So no matter what we do onstage, we gon' always look cool. Just keep it real natural. Like if you just want to walk out onstage and give your man a pound or whatever, that's cool, that's how we gon' do it!'"

David Herskovits hopped on the bus to cover the tour for the New York Daily News. They planned to play seven dates in France and England on the two-week tour. "They had this whole show," he remembers, "It wasn't just a band, it was the graffiti and the breakdancers and the DJs and the whole experience."

After long bus trips broken up only by full-scale tagging and pilfering attacks at the gas stops, the twenty-five-member entourage would head onstage to try to replicate the organic feel of the Roxy for the crowds. DST spun, and his rappers rapped. Bambaataa got up and played and the b-boys would get up and dance as the spirit moved them. The Double Dutch girls headed up for a few routines. FAB and RAMMELLZEE took turns on the mike, while FUTURA and DONDI painted live pieces.

Herskovits recalls, "Not too many people showed up to these shows. Especially some of these little towns where they didn't have a critical mass audience anyway. They're not the hippest people out there. We'd play in some school gymnasium in some town, maybe fifty kids would show up. And the French are not demonstrative, even in Paris where there was a decent turnout. I remember looking at the people and they would just sort of be looking at each other trying to figure out if they should like it or not. They didn't know quite how to react. It was so new."

Legs laughs, "Typical European audiences, man. But that's just the way it is. We were asked like really stupid questions like, 'Yo, are there trees in the Bronx?'"

In Strasbourg, France, they got a taste of that old Bronx River unpredictability. Crazy Legs recalls, "We did a show and there was these drunk people, and the Double Dutch girls were onstage doing their thing. They threw bottles at

them." The music stopped. D.ST armed himself with a broken bottle, PHASE 2 picked up a chair. "Next thing you know, people were backstage talking about, 'We gon' get them!' DONDI led the people out there. DONDI had his belt with his name buckle on and the dudes caught a beatdown. After they got beat down, everybody stepped back onstage, and then the people in the audience started clapping! It went from a show to a brawl to getting applause." Bambaataa went back to playing his records, and their legend was sealed. By the time they reached Paris, the media came out to meet them like they were the real thing.

When the hip-hop heroes returned to the Roxy, the innocence seemed to be fading. ZEPHYR says, "Everyone was trying to hustle something. Someone had an angle, someone was like, 'Can I take your picture?' 'Can I make a movie about you?' 'Can I do a series of shows at The Kitchen with you?' 'Can I write an article in *The Village Voice*?' "

Rolling Stone, *People* and *Life* came down with photographers and journalists. Fashion designers prepared their next year's lines by taking notes and trading numbers with the graffiti writers. Post-disco indie-label owners like Tom Silverman, Corey Robbins and Steve Plotnicki of Profile Records, Aaron Fuchs of Tuff City Records or Will Socolov of Sleeping Bag Records might be buying artists drinks at the bar. Soon these white-owned indies would eclipse the Black-owned ones; even the mighty Sugar Hill never recovered from the acrimonious collapse of its biggest act, Flash and the Five. Harry Belafonte had begun to soak up ideas for a multimillion dollar Hollywood movie that would be called *Beat Street*. A year later, the Roxy's owner ousted Kool Lady Blue. The dispute, she says, was over money.

A Little Story That Must Be Told

Perhaps the most lasting tribute to the spirit of '82 is the movie that Charlie Ahearn, Fab 5 Freddy, and Lee Quiñones gathered to talk about in the abandoned massage parlor in Times Square, *Wild Style*. The movie captured the sense of discovery, the new thing in all its raw, unpolished glory.

Perhaps much of its wonder had to do with its surrender to the culture. Ahearn—whose previous movie, *The Deadly Art of Survival*, had been shot on Super 8, with its main budget expense going to "buying pizza for the kids"—ad-

mits, "I'd never written a script. I really had no connection to the movie business whatsoever. I had never been to film school or been in the film business. But everyone accepted me as a Hollywood movie producer right off the bat. It was a matter of innocence on all sides."

Ahearn was out, he says, to make a "Bruce Lee movie. A simple hero, a simple story. Lee Quiñones was gonna be the hero. What is his problem? He's in love with this girl but she doesn't know he's the famous graffiti artist. That's it. That's all the movie is. And in a way, it reflected exactly how I saw things—in a comic book fashion."

The movie's principals were heads in the scene. There were no professional actors. PINK says, "There was a script that we all chuckled about. Picture that, a white guy just introduced to the scene and he's trying to write slang. That was funny!"

But Ahearn also truthfully described the scene's deepening schisms. ZEPHYR says, "The whole thing of the whole sensibilities of the downtown and the uptown, and the woman Neva who wants to seduce Lee—'Oh can I buy your painting? Oh sit down!' All that shit seems like it's laughable when you watch the movie, and yet it all happened. All those things were so real. Charlie didn't say, 'I'm gonna parody the scene.'"

By now he was deep in it, enough to understand the subtleties of off-screen realities like PINK and Lee's tortured relationship. Lee had refused to star in the movie until Ahearn made two things clear. If he did it, he would be paid. If he didn't, someone else would have to do the scripted love scenes with PINK. "When we shot the scene where Lee goes to the art collector, and he's supposed to be in bed with this woman, that could have been something else entirely," he says. "PINK found out that he was shooting this scene. She showed up at that apartment. She sat right between the camera and Lee the entire time. That's why he was so nervous. And like, you know, it was hard to direct!"

During Charlie and Fab's yearlong advanced seminar in the post-"Rapper's Delight" club scene, they walked into a marquee rivalry between Charlie Chase's Cold Crush Brothers and Grand Wizard Theodore's Fantastic Five Freaks, which became a major organizing theme for the movie. They caught the rappers on the stoop and in the limo, at the Dixie and the Amphitheatre, even on the basketball court. Over wickedly exciting dubplate special riddims—cut by

Blondie's Chris Stein with FAB and a downtown session band and recut Bronx-style by Theodore, Chase, DST and KK Rockwell—they captured three of the most electrifying, influential ensemble routines ever committed to tape.

Here was Fantastic's Prince Whipper Whip, channeling H. Rap Brown: "I am the New Yorker, the sweet walker, the woman stalker, the jive talker, the money maker"—bragging about being "the least conceited". And undefeated, at least until Cold Crush's JDL dispensed him with a shrug: "If you still got money and you wanna bet, well I bet a hundred dollars that I'm not whipped yet."

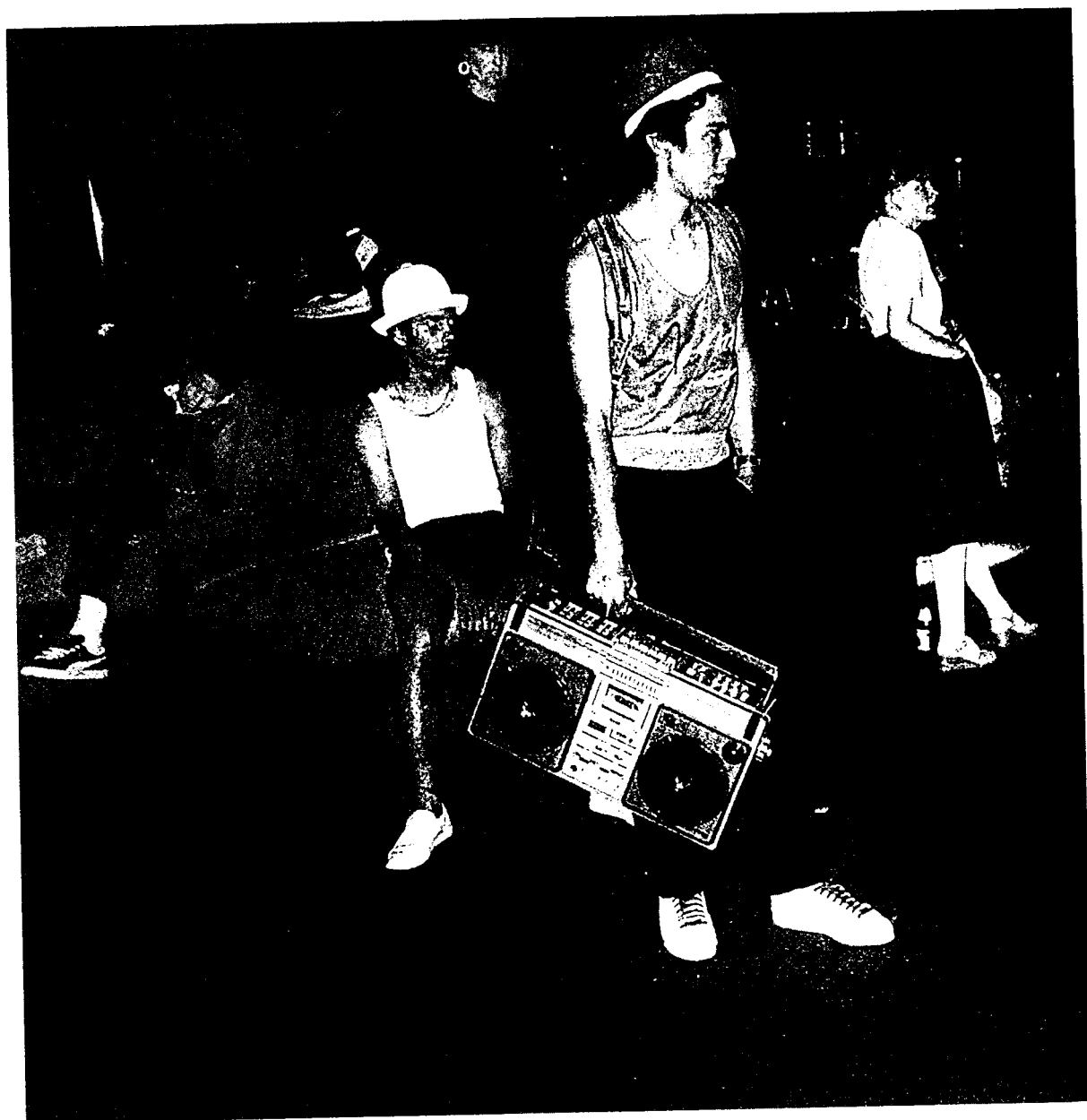
The movie's climax was a feverish reimagining of a Bronx park jam, another downtown presentation of the four elements, but with one crucial difference. Instead of taking hip-hop up-market, *Wild Style* went back to the people hip-hop came from. Ahearn had always been concerned about *where* he screened the work as much as *what* was being shown. That was why *The Deadly Art of Survival* and his hip-hop slides always looped back to be shown in their points of genesis: the Smith Houses, the Bronx clubs. His greatest ambition for *Wild Style* had been to screen it in Times Square for the b-boys and b-girls, the street rappers, the Five Percenters, all the folks from around the way. Here, once again, was representation as liberation, art as activism. So the show was staged at an abandoned amphitheater near the Williamsburg Bridge in East River Park.

The cast and crew cleaned it and fixed it up and Lee and others painted it into full hip-hop glory. Then they invited all the neighborhoods to the party. In a sense, it really was a park jam. No permits, no city fees, it was wholly a self-generated creation. The night of the shoot, thousands had gathered and the show was getting into full swing when the law finally showed up. As the police car pulled near the gate, Ahearn ran over, clipboard in hand, and said, "Oh man, I'm so glad you guys showed up. We thought you would never get here. We just need you to stand right here and help us keep this thing together." The cops took one look at the scene, got back in their car, and drove off, never to return.

Aside from such regular displays of improvisational genius from the producers and performers, the brilliance of *Wild Style* lay in the decision of Charlie and FAB never to cork the ferocious competitive energy, the feverish call-and-response, the phantasmic sense of possibility present in a hip-hop moment. *Wild*

Style remains the only hip-hop film and soundtrack that adequately conveys the communal thrill of merging with the tide, riding the lightning.

The timeless moment of *Wild Style* is the night before Reagan's morning, sad mourning, in America. Shockdell is talking homelessness like a prophet. Ikonoklast panzer RAMMELLZEE strides onstage waving a sawed-off shotgun in one hand, reaching down and pulling rhymes out his pocket with the other. One second he's stepping out at Cypress Hills, beating down a toy with his def graffiti, the next he's signing off with an apple-pie flourish, shouting out the Rock Steady on the linoleum and the cops in the crowd. That ricochet unpredictability, that badder-than-bold, bolder-than-bad chest-thumping, the volatile combo of sociology-shattering disbelief and Sunday-morning faith it inspired in anyone it touched—all this was *Wild Style's*, and 1982's, gift to the world.



Waiting for something to happen: FUTURA 2000 (foreground), Anita Sarko (background), b-boy, and bobby-soxer at the Roxy.

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